The Truth about Cats and Dogs

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Explicit

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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The Truth about Cats and Dogs

by Enigm17a

Summary

Adora volunteers at an animal shelter as a way to destress from her job as a rookie for the Bright Moon fire department. She gets to hang out with cats and dogs and make their lives a little bit better. It's perfect! Or would be perfect were it not for Catra, the kennel manager with the stick up her butt.

or

The Catradora animal shelter fic we all have been waiting for. Maybe.

Notes

I hope to publish a chapter or two a week. I'll change the rating if things escalate but keeping it at mature for now. I was told that I must be on tumblr to truly be in the She-ra fandom so I joined this morning. lol. @enigm17a. NO idea what I'm doing on there yet.

This is fanfic #2 for me. So still getting my feet wet. So happy to hear your feedback and input. Comments are my virtual Nutella.

Not beta read, hopefully I kept my errors to a minimum.

Chapter 1

Adora was paying very close attention to Netossa, the orientation leader. She had been on the waitlist to volunteer at the Bright Moon Animal Welfare Society (BAWS) for weeks and she was excited to get started.

"Every time you start your shift, be sure to sign in on this clipboard and note your time of arrival. The animals rely on your shift, so if you are unable to make it, please make an effort to find a substitute to take your place and/or tell the shift leaders in advance so we can attempt to replace you. Your shift could be the difference in a dog getting to go out for a walk in the morning or having to relieve themselves in their room."

Adore nodded solemnly. These poor dogs! She was so glad she could help. She really wanted to get a dog; but her apartment didn't allow pets and she frankly she didn't have time to commit to a dog right now anyway. She was in a rookie with the Bright Moon Fire Department, Engine 17. Her hours were too inconsistent to reliably take care of an animal. This was a great alternative. Her friend Glimmer suggested volunteering as a way to scratch the dog owning itch. She might have been wrong though because it was 98% likely she would fall for the first animal she walked.

"You will typically sign up for a 2-hours shift, though you're always welcome to stay longer. Please note that your responsibilities will differ based on when you arrive. Morning crew typically take the dogs out for their first walk and may hang out in their rooms to do some socialization or training. The late morning crew will likely tidy up rooms, or fold laundry or do restocking, etc. We have a very small team of full-time staff and they're typically very busy helping to arrange transport, fosters, adoptions and so we rely on our volunteers to supplement all aspects of this rescue. As much as we all love cuddling our animals, sometimes the work isn't glamourous. One day we might need help answering voicemails, another day, we might need help mopping the floor."

Adora took notes in her little spiral steno pad about each task Netossa outlined; where the food was, how to properly sanitize dog toys and bowls, ideas for socialization, how to identify the level of concerns of each animal (low concern, moderate concern, high concern).

"Dogs who are listed as 'high concern' need special handling and support; please do not approach these animals because they might be aggressive. Often, they've come from backgrounds where they were abused or targeted, some even came from dog fighting rings. We do our very best to rehabilitate these dogs. Our full-time staff will take the lead on these poor pups, so as well intentioned as you might be, please don't go into their rooms without explicit permission from a full-time member."

Hearing this, Adora's heart broke a little bit. Dog fighting rings! These poor pups had been through so much.

"Now I know you are all here for the dog orientation, however if you are interested in helping with the cats, we will be hosting the cat orientation tomorrow. We have a few spots left for that orientation. Come see me afterwards to sign up."

She was very interested! She loved cats as well. Freshman year of high school she rescued feral kittens from the alley behind her school and 'hid' them in her bedroom. She was covered in welts and dark red scratches for weeks before Octavia, her foster mother, noticed and forced her to take them to a shelter. She then made her get a part time job to pay for the flee treatment the house required after their stay. Happily, the shelter socialized the kittens and put them up for adoption. Adora followed their progress via the shelter website. She was so relieved they hadn't been euthanized. Unsurprisingly, Octavia did not stay her foster mother for too long after that.

She wondered if she could make time for this second orientation! That way she could volunteer for both. Slow down Adora, she told herself. You barely have time for one two hour shift a week, let alone two!

"Ideally, you'd take the same shift weekly, but we understand that not everyone has that type of availability. Biweekly or monthly volunteers are also welcome. Please note though that if you have not volunteered in over 6 months; you will have to retake the volunteer orientation before you can sign up for a shift once more."

At the end of the training, the volunteers were going to have a chance to walk a dog with one of the seasoned volunteers. Netossa introduced the new volunteers to Bow; he had been volunteering for over a year. Adora looked at him with contained amusement. She couldn't believe a dog walker would be wearing a crop top. It didn't look like the safest choice, but he was rocking the queen of hearts t-shirt he was wearing.

"Hey guys! I am so glad you're here! These dogs are amazing, and I think you'll all do a great job walking them!" His enthusiasm was adorable and quite infectious. Adora couldn't wait!

Bow demonstrated the correct way to open the door to a dog's room so that they don't run out and how to properly leash them. They all went outside together, each taking turns handling a sandy haired pit bull mix named Frosta. She was a young and energetic pup with a tendency to jump on whoever was walking her. Bow showed them how to properly redirect her. When it was Adora's turn, she took the leash and held out a hand for Frosta to sniff. Afterwards she gently scratched her behind her ears; Frosta looked up at her with a panting dog smile and they started to walk together.

"Great job Adora! That was perfect."

Adora proudly smiled before handing the leash to the next trainee.

After the orientation, Adora found Netossa to sign up for the next day's orientation. Netossa gratefully led her to the cat section so she could put her name down. Walking to the back of the shelter, Adora noticed two staff members wearing maroon BAWS tshirts handling small kittens. The taller staff member looked a little

intimidating. She had short platinum hair with an impressive undercut and scorpion tattoo on her arm. Her shorter companion had long wavy dark hair, wild around her head. Freckles dotting the perfect dark olive skin around her nose. Peeking through her tshirt, a tattoo sleeve. Adora couldn't help noticing that her jeans were a little too tight. She swallowed looking at her. Who was that! Before she could process that thought, she saw, rather than heard Netossa talking to the beautiful wavy-haired goddess. Adora shook her head to snap herself out of the turned-on haze she was in so she could listen.

"…tomorrow. She just finished the dog orientation as well." Netossa turned to Adora, "Adora, this is Catra, she's our Kennel Manager and Cat Intake Lead."

Catra looked at Adora quickly and nodded, mostly focusing on the tiny kitten in her hands. Adora desperately wanted to hold this tiny fluff ball and wouldn't have minded petting the kitten's handler either. That thought brought a quick flush to her face and she was grateful neither of the staff seemed to be looking directly at her.

"And this is Scorpia, she is one of our veteran vet techs," Netossa introduced Adora to the taller woman with the scorpion tattoo.

"It so nice to meet you, Adora!" Scorpia exclaimed. Adora smiled at her.

Netossa got Adora signed up for the next day and thanked her again for coming in.

As Adora started to look for the exit, Scorpia stopped her from behind.

"Hey, Adora. Want to stay and meet some of the cats?"

Adora almost yelped with excitement, "I'd love that!"

Scorpia grinned, "Great! Follow me," gesturing to a room behind them with her non kitten holding hand.

“This is the nursery, where the babies and mamas stay when they’re still nursing or bottle fed.” She holds up the cute furball she was carrying, “This is Starla, she and her siblings, Jewelstar and Tallstar, were found abandoned in an alley a few days ago. Sadly, their mama wasn’t there to take care of them, so we’ve had to bottle feed them around the clock until they are old enough to get weaned.” Adora’s eyes opened up wide. These were little orphaned kittens. “I’m about to fix this one a bottle, want to help?” Adora nodded eagerly. Scorpia directed her to wash her hands and to grab one of the bottles she had sitting in a warm dish of water and sit down in a chair with a towel in her lap.

She gently transferred Starla into Adora’s hands and directed her to hold the kitten on the towel, positioning the bottle above her, making sure the kitten was not on her back so as not to asphyxiate. Adora introduced the tiny bottle and Starla latched on immediately, her little ears fluttering as she drank. Adora was in awe. This was quite possibly the cutest thing she’d ever done. When she had fostered the kittens in high school, they had already been weaned so she didn’t have to bottle feed them like this. This was so cool! After she was done, Scorpia gave her a soft rag to wash the kittens face and showed her how to stimulate the kitten to eliminate. Adora was glad to have a towel in her lap as the little kitten peed on her. She chuckled at the hilarity of being peed on.

“Well, you’re a natural, I think she likes you!” Scorpia laughed encouragingly at her. “Let’s put her back and feed her siblings.”

Scorpia opened the nursery cage. She took Starla and placed her on top of some towels, warmed from the heating pad below. She took out Jewelstar and handed her to Adora and picked up Tallstar. They each got to work feeding their respective kittens. Adora could do this all day.

Adora was so happy to be meeting these kittens and was grateful Scorpia was taking the time to teach her, but she couldn’t help noticing Catra working near them in complete silence. It was a little uncomfortable. Why wasn’t she saying anything to them?

Had she done something wrong? Adora bit her lip thoughtfully and shook her head to herself. She didn't think so.

After they were done, Scorpia toured the rest of the nursery, introducing Adora to the other kittens and mamas in residence. There were so many different little family units. They finally approached the litter that Catra was handling.

"Wildcat, can you introduce us to this cutie."

"Scorpia, please don't call me that at work."

Scorpia looked a little embarrassed, her fair skin turning a little red, she cleared her throat, "Sorry, Catra."

Catra gave a curt nod, and in almost a monotone voice introduced them to little Peakablue. She perked up a little bit when talking about him.

"Recently weaned, this fella tends to hide from the staff. Often going missing for hours."

"Oh boy, does he! Yesterday I thought for sure he had escaped! I finally found him hiding under the pallet of kitten food. How he manages to escape I just don't know." Scorpia seemed back to good humor. Catra gave her an indulgent smile and walked away to put Peakablue back in his cage.

Adora thanked Scorpia for the tour and told her she'd be back the next day for orientation.

"Oh great! I won't be there but Catra does a good job going over everything. Thanks for volunteering! I'm sure I'll see you soon."

Adora nodded with a smile but had a hard time picturing Catra doing a whole lot of talking.

She wasn’t wrong. At the cat orientation the next night, Catra didn’t waste her time on small talk with the volunteers. She certainly explained everything that they would need to know, but she brief and curt. Running through the routines and expectations, barely making eye contact with anyone. Like somehow this orientation was a waste of her time. Adora started getting annoyed. They were all there during their free time so they could help animals and she was acting like they were all bothering her. It was infuriating. She couldn’t believe someone could be that rude.

Catra finished up orientation with a reminder to the trainees about how to sign up for shifts. Everyone started heading out after. Adora was one of the last to leave, packing up her notes from orientation. Catra was still there, still not making eye contact and not acknowledging her.

“Um,” Adora cleared her throat, “Is everything okay?”

Catra looked up, surprised Adora was talking to her. She burrowed her brow, shook her head slightly and looked back down.

“Yep.” She replied without ceremony

Adora let out a humph.

“Can I help you?!” Catra responded, annoyed.

Adora couldn’t help herself, though her friends always begged her to try, “It just seems like you resent all of us being here, wasting your time. We are all just trying to help the shelter and the animals.”

“Oh, is that right, Princess? Thanks so much for clarifying. I am sooo sorry that I’m not kissing your feet for being here and spending your precious time trying to ‘help’ the poor animals.” She snapped back.

“What is your problem?!” Adora responded, truly perplexed by her snippy behavior.

“I don’t have a problem; you seem to have a problem. Thank you so much for being here and volunteering your time. I’m SURE I’ll see you back here again soon.” Sarcasm still dripping from every word.

“Wow, you’re kind of an ass.” Calling someone an ass was probably the meanest thing Adora could think of to say to someone.

“Whatever, Princess.”

“Why do you keep calling me ‘Princess’?”

Catra looked down at the sweatshirt Adora was wearing. Adora had to look down too, she had no clue what she put on that day. It was a simple grey sweatshirt with the Basquiat Crown symbol on it. A gift from Glimmer, who majored in art.

“It’s Basquiat.”

“I know who it is,” Catra responded.

They were both quiet. Adora felt a little deflated. What did she think she was going to accomplish antagonizing her? Clearly, she had some stick up her ass and Adora calling her out on it wasn’t going to fix anything. Finally, Adora spoke.

“Um. Okay. I guess thanks for the orientation. Have a good night.”

“Whatever,” Catra mumbled under her breath. But looked a little less haughty when she met Adora’s eyes.

Adora walked outside a little frazzled. It took her three tries to unlock Swift Wind, her sparkly white bike with rainbow stickers. As she put on her unicorn helmet, she started to give herself a pep talk. Just because this frustrating Catra character worked at BAWS doesn’t mean this still couldn’t be a great experience for her. Working with the animals was what she needed to get her pet fix and get some distance from the stressors of her job. She won’t let Catra distract from that. Ever the optimist, by the time she started

riding towards home she had convinced herself that volunteering would be a fun and happy experience.

Affirmations

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Come in," Glimmer yelled through the door. Adora let herself into Glimmers little cottage. "I hope you brought the food."

"I wouldn't dare show up without it." Adora responded, throwing off her shoes and helmet and wheeling Swift Wind inside. Glimmer was sitting crossed legged on the couch, wearing her purple pajamas and fluffy purple house slippers.

"Yum, I'm glad you suggested 'Naan Better,' I haven't gotten Indian in a while. I can't wait to dig into their samosas."

Adora spread out the takeout on Glimmers coffee table, placing one container of food in front of Glimmer and two containers of food in front of her. That should hold her over for a few hours. She dug out the samosas and naan and put them on top of the napkins.

"Booze?"

"Yes please, I'll take a cider," Adora said with a smile. "Where is Perfuma tonight?"

"She's taking a yoga class with Mermista."

"Ah, sounds…terrible. Hope they have fun though."

Glimmer laughed and put on some Netflix while they inhaled their dinner.

"That was delicious!" Glimmer exclaimed, laying down flat on the couch, legs on Adora's lap. "I might not be able to move for a few days."

“A sign of a good meal.” Adora laughed, happily full herself.

“How was orientation yesterday? Were the cats as fun as the dogs?”

“The cats are wonderful! I’m excited to work with them. But I had a bit of situation with the orientation leader.” Adora told her all about Catra and their snipping session. Mentioning how she couldn’t help herself.

“Wow, she sounds like a piece of work. In this case I think it’s okay you didn’t hold back. I can’t believe they let someone like her work there!”

“I know! What an ass!”

Glimmer laughed hearing Adora curse.

“I love when you get angry.”

“I was pretty pissed. What sucks too is when I first saw her, you know *before* the orientation, I thought she was hot. Like super-duper painfully hot. And then she had to go and ruin it with her personality.”

“Sometimes the hot ones are the ones to avoid.” She grinned, “Obviously, *we* are the exception to the rule.”

Adora rolled her eyes with a laugh. *Obviously*!

Glimmer continued, “Okay, topic change! Want to scroll Tinder with me?”

“Glimmer!” Adora responded, exasperated. She was tired of Glimmer trying to fix her up. “I have no time to date right now, you know that!”

“Rude! I don’t mean for you. I mean for me!”

“Oooh, in that case, yes! Let’s get to swiping!”

Glimmer pulled out her phone, covered in a sparkly pink case and pulled up the app. They laughed at some of their options. Especially when they came across people they knew.

"Perfuma!" They both yelled out. "Aww she looks so cute in that picture. Is that from the drum circle a few weeks ago?" Adora asked.

"Yeah, I think so. That was a good time."

"Agreed."

A sweet looking boy named 'Kyle' popped up next, he had blonde hair and dark eyes. "Aww, look at this precious thing, he looks like someone I might eat for breakfast. NEXT!"

A picture of Scorpia came next, she was holding a basket of kittens and grinning from ear to ear.

"Oh! I know her! She works as a vet tech at BAWS. Look at those kittens. This is a great photo of her."

"Very cute, but not my type," Glimmer said as she swiped left. Adora laughed at her. She was speeding through everyone they saw.

"You do realize you haven't swiped right even once?"

"I know *you're* not lecturing me about being picky."

Adora looked amusedly guilty. Fair point.

"Yum. Who is this!" Glimmer sat up straight on the couch. There on her phone was a photo of Bow. He was wearing a Keith Haring Heart tshirt which barely covered his navel. In the next photo, he seemed to be at a renaissance fair. In the pic, he was pulling an arrow on a fancy looking bow, wearing a medieval looking kilt.

"I know him too! He volunteers at BAWS. Works with the dogs. Very sweet, very enthusiastic. And even more handsome in

person.”

Glimmer swiped right and crossed her fingers to see if there was a match. No alert appeared and she looked crestfallen. Pouting.

“He probably didn’t see you yet. Give it a little while. I’m sure once he sees you, he’ll also swipe right.”

Glimmer looked sad, but hopeful, “You think so?”

“Of course, I do.”

A few hours later, Adora was at home reading in bed. Her phone buzzed. Text from Glimmer. She opened it to find a screen grab from Tinder. It read ‘It’s a match!’ with a picture of Bow and a photo of Glimmer.

Adora:
Yaaaay, I told you so

Glimmer wrote back a “wipe brow” emoji.

Adora fell asleep smiling, happy for her friend.

Adora mapped out her schedule and was able to carve out one day every week for volunteering. She was available almost every Tuesday afternoon, so she decided she’d alternate helping with the cats and the dogs. She was a both nervous and excited. The first Tuesday she signed up to volunteer with the cats. She was sure she’d have a cat escape on her first day. Then Catra would definitely be pissed at her, and this time with good reason. She got to work as soon as she arrived. She changed the water dishes, filled their food bowls, cleaned their litter. She started to feel more comfortable with each cat she helped. Giving each kitty a little love and attention as she went along. She whispered some positive affirmations to each one when she wrapped up cleaning their cage.

She held each one and said, “You are smart, you are sweet, you are beautiful. You are worthy of lots of love. It is not your fault that you are here. Someone is going to see you and fall head over heels for you and you’ll go to your forever home soon.”

Catra walked by the room while she was giving a cute calico cat the little affirmations she invented. She looked at the cat, then up at her, narrowed her eyes and kept on walking. Adora was annoyed. Why did she have to be so rude!

The cat in her arms felt her tension and almost sprinted out of her grip. Adora managed to wrangle him back in the cage, but not without a fight. Her hair, usually up in a semi-permanent ponytail, was completed misshapen.

It was of course in that moment that Catra walked by again. Giving her a once over again. Her face clearly indicating that she thought she looked insane.

“What!” Adora snapped.

Catra’s lips twitched as she looked up at her, she shook her head and kept walking.

“What an ass,” Adora mumbled to no one. The calico gave her a look of confusion, his head tilted. “Not you sweet boy, you’re perfect.”

Still pretty riled up by that brief interaction, she decided to wonder over to the kitten nursery at the end of her shift. Scorpia was there again.

“Adora! So nice to see you again! How was your first day volunteering?”

“It was great! The cats are so sweet. I am so glad I decided to volunteer with them too.”

“Aren’t they wonderful! I am so glad that they’re here. We have a great adoption turnaround at this location.”

Adora smiled happily. She was glad to hear it. She could feel herself calming down after her brief interaction with Catra. Scorpia let her feed the kittens again. Holding their tiny little bodies in her hands help her relax even more.

She had to pass Catra's office on her way to collect her bag and helmet. The door was open, and the walls were glass so she could a full view of Catra typing away furiously at her computer. She had a pen haphazardly stuck in her hair, holding it up in a loose curly bun at the back of her head accentuating her nape. Adora hadn't noticed earlier how the BAWS polo she was wearing clung beautifully to her body. The short-sleeved shirt not quite skintight but not loose either. She got a better look at the tat under her sleeve. She observed a purple cat-like creature with glowing bright blue eyes and almost a glowing halo around its neck. Very interesting. Her mouth got dry. For a moment Adora forgot how annoying she found Catra. She found herself staring inappropriately for long enough that she didn't realize Catra had looked up and caught her looking.

"Can I help you?"

Adora's eyes snapped up to Catra's face, her face turning red from the guilt and panic of being caught staring.

"Um. Nice weather we're having today."

Catra glanced over to the window at the overcast skies and turned back to Adora in confusion.

"Uh…sure."

"I mean, that we were having. I guess it's not nice weather now. I mean, but it was. Earlier." Adora trailed off. Feeling ridiculous.

"Sure." She paused, squinting at her, "Are you okay?" Catra looked at her like she was losing her mind, strangely the look wasn't totally unkind. She looked almost concerned. That made Adora mad, in addition to feeling embarrassed.

“Yes. Of course, I’m okay. Have a have a nice day I guess.” Adora, red, spit out at her and ran down the hall to the cubby with her stuff. Could she be more embarrassing? No, probably not. Though if she thought Adora was crazy, maybe she’d forget she was ogling her. It didn’t matter. It’s not like Catra liked her anyway. She shook her head, what a day! She put on her unicorn helmet and headed out the door.

“We’ve been texting all week!” Glimmer told Adora. They were on the phone, Glimmer’s voice practically chirped in happiness.

“That’s awesome Glimmer! I’m so excited for you.” Adora said, a little out of breath.

“What are you doing that you’re huffing so much.”

“Right now? Pushups. After this, lunges.”

“Do you have to do it while we’re on the phone?”

“You called in the middle of my routine; my training is not negotiable. Do you have any idea how heavy a fire ladder is? Or the hose for that matter. I’m the only woman at this fire station, I’m the first woman in fact! No way am I going to give some of these guys a reason to resent me. I have to stay on top of my game. You’re lucky we’re talking now; I was doing burpees right before you called.”

Adora could almost hear Glimmer rolling her eyes.

“Adora, you’re one of the strongest people I know. You could probably pull a fire engine on your own if you needed to.”

She laughed, “Happily, that’s not part of the regimen, but yesterday they had us lay on the ground and bench press the ladder together in unison as a team building exercise. Boy were my biceps burning.”

“I say this as your friend. Your very platonic best friend. That’s super-hot.”

“Glimmer!”

“I mean. It is!”

“Okay, that’s enough of that.”

“You have to learn how to take a compliment.”

“Thank you,” Adora said sarcastically. Still out of breath. “Back to you and Bow. Have you made plans to see each other yet?”

“Not yet, but I think he’s working up the courage to ask me out. But my patience is limited so if he doesn’t ask soon, I’ll do it myself.”

“I’m kind of surprised you haven’t already asked, it’s not like you to wait for a guy to ask.”

“I know, but I really like him and I’m a little nervous. It’s nice, he’s nice, I’m afraid of messing it up by being ‘too Glimmery’.”

“I love that you just made your name into an adjective. Glimmer, you’re awesome. He’d be lucky to go out with you.”

“I know…but I’m still nervous.”

“That’s adorable. This whole thing with you and Bow is adorable.”

“I like him.”

“So, you’ve said.”

“Okay, enough about me, how about you? Didn’t you start volunteering this week?”

“Yup. I don’t know how I left BAWS without adopting a cat.” Adora laughed.

“Stay strong, Adora! You don’t have time for a pet.”

“I know.” Adora pouted thinking about the cute kitties she’d met. “Happily, Scorpia told me that their adoption turnover is pretty fast. So, they won’t be there for long.”

“That’s great! Any Catra sightings?”

“Um. About that.” Adora told her about their several embarrassing interactions. Glimmer paused.

“I think you have a crush, Grayskull.”

“I do not!”

“Adora! You stared at her boobs, in a polo. That’s pretty gay.”

“Well, I’m pretty gay, but it doesn’t mean I’m gay for her?”

“Doesn’t it?”

“No?”

Glimmer laughed at the question mark in her no, “Just cause you want to jump her doesn’t mean you’re getting married. Maybe her being a bitch would make the sex even hotter.”

“Glimmer!”

“I mean, some of the best sex I’ve ever had was with someone I truly didn’t like.”

“Glimmer!” Adora could feel her heart start racing and it had nothing to do with the lunges.

“Adora! Come on. If she’s as hot as you have told me she is, you might want to pursue that.”

“You’re infuriating!” Adora was done with this line of conversation, “Stop it. She’s an ass. An obnoxious, angry misanthrope. Just

cause she’s objectively very attractive, doesn’t mean I want anything to do with her.”

“Misanthrope? Look who decided to eat their Wheaties this morning.”

Adora rolled her eyes, “Okay friend. I think it’s time we get off the phone. I have some jumping jacks to do.”

“Sure, Adora. Try not to think about Catra while doing them.” Glimmer laughed, hanging up.

Adora shook her head. Glimmer was so good at getting into her head. Now all she could think about was Catra. How that top clung to her body, the way little bits of her hair brushed along her neck, those beautiful full lips she had been biting in concentration. She could kill Glimmer!

Chapter End Notes

Comments are my virtual Nutella :)

follow me on tumblr at enigm17a (I still don't know what I'm doing on there)

If you liked this, take a gander at my other Catradora fanfic.

Happy Hour

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

This week she was volunteering with the dogs. She was so excited to get started, she even got there early. She was glad she did because it meant she got to spend a little time with Bow who was wrapping up his shift. He was telling her what dogs he thought she should spend a little bit more time with.

As he was talking, Adora was debating whether to bring up Glimmer. It was absolutely not her business and definitely inappropriate, and for sure Glimmer would kill her but… she couldn't help herself.

"I know Glimmer," she blurted, smacking herself in the face with her hand.

"Glimmer?" he responded, surprised. And then his face started to turn a lovely shade of purple.

"Sorry, I shouldn't have blurted or said anything at all. She's one of my best friends. I heard you two were talking." Adora cleared her throat, "I put in a good word for you with her." She smiled. Hoping that butting in wouldn't put her on Glimmer's shit list.

Bow tried to compose himself and started to grin, "She's great! I really like talking to her." He started to look a little shy, a sheen of sweat appearing on his forehead, "I've been wanting to ask her out but keep getting nervous. Honestly, I'm not sure what she'd say."

"Yes. She'd say yes." Adora couldn't help herself. Glimmer was definitely not going to be pleased.

"Yeah?"

“Yeah.”

“Well, alright! I’m so glad I talked to you.”

Adora breathed a sigh of relief. Maybe it wasn’t terrible that she decided to insert herself in someone else’s business. Still. She really needed to stop doing that.

The rest of the shift was uneventful. Bow had walked all the dogs, so her job was just to hang out and help socialize them. She ran through some commands with the young pups who needed to learn a little discipline. Read to the older pups who just wanted a little company. Brushed the scruffier ones who needed a little pampering. She loved this time at BAWS. The dogs were so sweet and loveable. And gratefully she left the kennel area without trying to adopt any of them.

She had to pass the cat area on her way out. As she did, she overheard Catra and Scorpia talking frantically.

“Wildca… Catra, stop worrying. We have enough space! And if we don’t, I know we have a few extra cages in storage that can be set up in a jiffy.” Scorpia said slowly, trying to calm Catra down.

“I just can’t believe they sent us sixteen cats! I told them we could only take ten.” Catra’s voice sounded frazzled. Adora snuck a peak and saw that Catra looked disheveled, her hair was a bit messy around shoulders, and her shirt was stained. Typically, she looked a little to put together for someone working at an animal shelter. “Normally, I think that we could figure it out, but since the last two volunteers failed to show we are so behind already. We haven’t even finished prepping the ten cages we were supposed to have set up by now. There is no way we can get it all done in the next hour.” Adora could hear the stress and bitterness in her voice. That sucked. What’s wrong with people! Volunteering is a commitment.

Adora wanted to help but was also anxious about letting them know she was eavesdropping. Finally, she decided the need for

assistance outweighed the need for privacy. She cleared her throat, stepped forward into the room and tentatively asked, "Can I do anything?"

Scorpia and Catra looked up at her. Scorpia smiled, happy to see her. Catra looked annoyed and vaguely suspicious. No surprise there.

"Seriously, let me help. I just finished up with the dogs and I have some time to spare." Not technically true. She was pretty tired from her shift yesterday. She hadn't gotten enough sleep at the fire house. She had planned a circuit workout at home tonight and an early bedtime. But despite all that, she knew she had to assist.

"Wow, you are awesome! Thank you!" Scorpia jumped in with instructions, "Okay. Adora, you and Catra can start cleaning out and prepping the cages we have here and I'll run to storage to find some of the extra cages. I think we can make it work in an hour. Right Catra?"

Adora and Scorpia both looked at Catra. She still looked annoyed but seemed more willing to accept the help.

"Alright," she finally said. Like she was doing Adora the favor instead of the other way around. Adora rolled her eyes. Sure, Catra was hot. She could admit it to herself, but she was such an ass! But despite that, she could feel herself flushing in her presence. Her didn't a mirror to know her neck was warm. She needed a moment to collect herself.

"Okay, sounds like a plan," Adora said lightly, attempting to sound normal. "I'm going to go wash my hands and I'll be right back."

As she lathered up at the sink, she took a few calming breaths and gave herself a little pep talk. 'Catra is just a hot asshole. You are here to help the cats. You will not stare at her again. You are here to help the cats. You don't need to talk to her. You are here to help the cats.'

She walked back with a better resolve. She would not let Catra get to her. She would not talk to her unless she absolutely had to.

Catra was already working on the cages. She had the disinfectant spray and a roll of paper towels.

"Do you want me to prep the cages after you clean them or vice versa? Assembly line style." There goes her resolution to stay silent.

Catra looked up and walked out of the room.

"UG!" Adora said out loud to no one. Ass!

Adora put some gloves on and started to clean the cages using the spray and paper towels Catra left behind. She was on cage number three when Catra finally returned. She was carrying a bin full of cat dishes for water and food. She left again and brought back a stack of clean towels. Then finally took one final trip for litter boxes and litter. They worked in silence. Adora cleaning and disinfecting the cages, while Catra prepped them with the necessities. Adora paused after finishing cage number ten. Catra was a few cages behind. Adora silently started helping her, prepping the water and food dishes, and putting them next to Catra to place inside. Scorpia returned, making a few trips to bring up the extra cages. They were clean but needed a fresh wipe down from the dust. Adora finished those off quickly.

It wasn't long after that they were all done. Catra looked up the clock. With the three of them working, they had wrapped up within forty-five minutes, fifteen minutes ahead of schedule. She cleared her throat and glanced quickly at Adora but focused her words mainly to Scorpia.

"I think we're ready, thank you."

Adora rolled her eyes quickly. She couldn't help herself. She didn't expect a formal letter of thanks, but some acknowledgement to her directly would have been nice.

“Adora, we couldn’t have done it without you! Thank you so much for staying. I know you must be busy.” Scorpia filled in where Catra was wanting. Practically smothering her in praise.

“No problem. I’m glad I can help. Should I stay for the transfer?” Adora looked pointedly only at Scorpia. If Catra wanted to continue ignoring her, then she could do the same.

“No, that’s okay Adora, I think we can manage it. The city shelter usually sends good staff that will assist.”

Adora smiled, paused for a moment, thinking maybe Catra might say something then. When she didn’t, Adora finally said, “Okay then. Have a goodnight. Scorpia, I’ll see you next Tuesday.”

Walking away, she could almost make out Scorpia saying something to Catra. She was pretty sure she heard her name. She slowed down hoping to catch some of what she was saying, but she was too far then. She shrugged. Oh well.

She started grabbing her stuff from the cubby. She was readjusting her ponytail so she could put on her helmet when she felt, rather than heard, someone behind her.

Thinking it was likely a volunteer, she pushed closer to the cubbies to make room for them to pass. When no one squeezed passed her she looked back and saw Catra.

She looked a little on edge, like she didn’t want to be standing there. Adora looked at her with a question.

When Catra didn’t speak, Adora finally huffed out, “Did you need something?”

Catra looked uncomfortable. She ran a hand through her curls and finally cleared her throat, “Thank you. Back there. For stepping in. I appreciate it. We couldn’t have done it in time without you.” She didn’t wait for Adora to respond. She twirled around and walked back.

Adora stood in shocked silence. Wow. Catra actually spoke to her. And thanked her. Sincerely! She wasn't sure who was more surprised, she or Catra.

Glimmer texted her later that night.

Glimmer:
He asked me out! I'm going to see him Saturday. I think he's going to take me to do target practice

Adora:
Target practice? Like with guns?

Glimmer:
No no, sorry. I don't actually know what it's called, but something to do with archery. He's going to teach me how to use his bow. She added a wink emoji.

Adora:
How do you manage to make thing sound dirty via text message

Glimmer:
Hey! It's not my fault his name is Bow and he's into bows

Adora rolled her eyes with a smile, Glimmer could make anything sounds kinky.

Adora:
Yay! I'm so glad for you.

Glimmer:
…

Adora:
What's the '…' for?

Glimmer:
I guess I should thank you but I'm also mad at you so '…' means I'm conflicted.

Uh oh. She knew what was coming.

Glimmer:
You said something to him about me!

Adora:
Oops. He told you?

Glimmer:
He is a terrible liar. Which I kind of like about him. He basically shared your entire conversation.

Adora:
Ha! I'll have to remember that for future. He clearly cannot be trusted. Though it's not like I told him not to tell you we spoke.

Glimmer:
Whatever, I forgive you. And thank you. I'm so excited to meet him in person. Maybe we could do a fashion show beforehand.

Adora:
Yes! I'm down. But it will have to be Friday, I have a shift Thursday.

Glimmer:
Sure. We can do that. Maybe dinner and a fashion show Friday?

Adora:
Yes please!

Late Saturday night, Adora got a blurry photo text from Glimmer. It was of her and Bow in a selfie. Which he must have taken because no way could Glimmer's arms go that far for that angle. Glimmer was wearing the purple track suit they picked out for her last night. Bow was wearing a cute sweatshirt with rainbows down the arms. The hem cut short at his midriff. They were both clearly drunk and grinning like fools. Adora smiled looking at it. It seemed like their date was going well.

Not long after the picture, Glimmer texted again.

Glimmer:
Happy Hour Monday! Salineas. Be there or be there.

Adora shook her head at the drunk rambling. Happy hour was unlikely to happen. She has a shift Sunday and she liked to treat Mondays like a vacation day if she could help it.

When she didn't bother replying, she received another drunken text ten minutes later.

Glimmer:
ADOOOOOOOOORAAAAAAAAAA.

Adora:
yes?

Glimmer:
Happy hourrrr???????????????

Adora:
You better not be driving tonight!

Glimmer:
nooooooo, we are uuuubering. Yes to happy hourrrr?

Adora:
Maybe

Glimmer texted back a selfie of her fake crying.

She then texted another photo, this time it was of Bow fake crying.

Finally, a group photo of both of them fake crying.

Adora:
Fine! I'll strongly consider it. I'm going to bed now. Remember no glove, no love.

Glimmer:
Adora!!!!

Adora laughed to herself. She was sure Glimmer was blushing. She was always so free with offering sex advice, but she could also be a little prudish when it came to receiving it.

Monday night, Adora arrived at Salineas Bar and Grill freshly showered following a day of intense lounging. She really would have preferred to stay home, eat her high protein and carb dinner, and pass out by 8pm. But knowing Glimmer would harass her if she failed to show she decided to save herself a headache. Glimmer texted earlier that Perfuma was joining them and Bow had invited some friends to join as well. As exhausted as she was, she was happy to spend some time with people outside the firehouse and especially with Bow. She suspected he was soon going to be regular in their group. She wasn't much of a drinker, but with Mermista bartending tonight she knew the drinks would be extra good.

As she walked in, she had to wade through a sea of people to find her friends. She finally saw Glimmer, Perfuma and Bow in the back waving her over. She smiled. Bow and Glimmer looked very cute together already. She hugged everyone hello.

"I'm so glad you decided to come," Glimmer grinned. Adora could tell from the goofy grin she was giving her that she wasn't on her

first drink.

“Me too,” Adora said begrudgingly. “But no promises for how long I can stay, I want to get to bed early.”

“It’s 6pm!?” Bow asked, confusion written all over his face.

“Adora is a rookie with the fire department; those muscles aren’t just for show.” Glimmer responded before Adora could say anything. “They’re really rough on the newbies and she’s constantly in training.”

“It’s not that bad,” Adora murmured. Though totally untrue. It felt like it was a step below hazing. Though most of the time, the work was intense for a reason.

“That’s so cool Adora! You’re a real-life superhero.” Bow said, in awe, his eyes getting bigger.

Adora blushed, getting a little self-conscious. She was very proud of having been accepted into the fire department. She had dreamt of doing this almost her entire life. It was cool when people appreciated her job, but it made her feel awkward to be the center of attention.

“I’m not a superhero yet, but I’m trying.”

“You’re also an EMT, right Adora?” Perfuma chimed in, her serene voice barely audible at the crowded bar.

“I am, it definitely helped me get a leg up when I was trying to get into the fire academy.” She paused, maybe it was time for some alcohol. “Okay drinks! I’m headed to the bar, anyone want anything?”

Glimmer looked down at her drink, still pretty full from their last round, “Nah, I’m good. Still nursing this one.”

Perfuma said the same.

Bow smiled, “Thanks, I think I’ll wait till my friends get here to order again. I think they’ll be here soon.”

Adora made her way over to the crowded bar and nodded to get Mermista’s attention. Mermista had worked at this bar for a few years now. She was actually the manager but typically helped with happy hour because of how slammed they got. Adora has known her for a few years now, Perfuma introduced them to her and they’ve all been friends ever since. Tonight, she looked incredibly sexy in her green pleather halter top and tight dark green shorts with an orange hanky in her left back pocket. Adora always found her a little too attractive for comfort and had a crush on her when the first met, but quickly realized they would made better friends then lovers. Also, she was never sure if she was queer, though she suspected that Mermista would be open to trying anything once (or twice). She suspected that she and Perfuma had a history, but neither of them ever fessed up to it. She had a feeling Mermista knew she found her attractive and messed with her just to get a reaction. Not that it was hard.

“Hi gorgeous,” Mermista grinned. Her smile electric. Adora laughed and blushed a little bit.

“Hi M,” Adora responded with a genuine smile. “How’s the night going?”

“Not bad! The crowd is good, not your usual 9-5’ers. The tips are good. Whacha havin’?

“You know I can never pick. Can you make me something you’d think I like?”

“Ooooh yes! I have the perfect drink for you. I concocted it this weekend.”

Mermista turned around and threw what looked like random ingredients in a blender. It almost looked like she was making her a salad or a smoothie, not a cocktail. Grapefruit, spinach, ginger, cucumber, apple, and some water all together in one messy heap.

While she was blending that she grabbed a tall glass, added gin and ice and poured the concoction through a strainer on top. Adding a small twist of grapefruit peal as garnish for the finish.

“Here you are, I call it the ‘Green Crush’.”

As Adora took a sip Seahawk sauntered over, “My sweet Mermista, what beautiful elixir are you giving our dear friend.”

Mermista rolled her eyes and didn’t bother to respond. Adora smirked. Another reason why she never hit on Mermista. Seahawk and she seemed to have the oddest relationship that she dared not interfere with.

“Ignore him,” Mermista said dryly.

“That’s impossible,” Adora gave SeaHawk a grin in greeting, “This is amazing M, almost healthy! It’s exactly up my alley.” She paused to take another sip. Delicious!

“How are you, Seahawk?”

“Any day I get to spend with my fair lady is a good day.” Mermista groaned hearing him talk about her.

Adora laughed, this guy was a riot. She handed Mermista her credit card, “Can I open a tab?”

“Are you share that’s how you want to pay me?” Mermista crooned. Seahawk looked aghast and Adora cleared her throat in response.

“…For now.” She mock winked at Mermista.

She couldn’t help herself. Messing with Seahawk was too much fun. He walked away in mock anger. A light blue handkerchief white stripes sticking out of his left pocket. Mermista smiled at her, enjoying their game.

“I’ll keep the rest cold for when you come back up, gorgeous.” Adora smiled her thanks.

She made her way back to her friends, still grinning. As she approached the table, her smile froze. Sitting there with Bow, Perfuma and Glimmer was none other than Scorpia and Catra.

Chapter End Notes

Notes: Mermista and Seahawk always struck me as people who would be in an open relationship and a little kinky. So, I added the handkerchief’s as a fun homage to the hanky code. http://eagleportland.com/HANKY-CODE.HTML

cocktail recipe: https://dietitiandebbie.com/green-juice-cocktail/
Next chapter gets a little spicy

As always, comments are my virtual Nutella. Newbie Tumblr account @enigm17a

Green Crush

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

They didn't see her yet, giving Adora a moment to collect herself and yes of course, to stare at Catra. Yes, Mermista was sexy but Catra was hot as hell. Her hair was down for once, a perfect set of curls just past her neck. She wore a tight maroon tank top, her tattoo sleeve prominently displayed, accentuating her strong arms and olive skin. Adora noticed a navy lacy bra strap sticking out underneath, a surprising touch she appreciated. A pair of tight jeans rounded out the outfit, highlighting her ass in a way that shouldn't be legal in public. It's like she stepped out of a 'dykes r us' catalog. Why did she have to be some damned attractive? And why was she here!?

Adora attempted to check her face, willing a happyish but passive expression before she got too close.

As she approached, Scorpia noticed her first. She barely had a chance to put down her drink before the platinum haired woman picked her up in a tight bear hug, taking nearly all the breath out of her lungs.

"Oh, my goodness, Adora! I didn't know you would be here!"

"Hi Scorpia," Adora smiled, Scorpia was such a sweetheart, it was easy to be relaxed in her presence, "I didn't know you would be here either. Glimmer invited me. I've known her and Perfuma forever." She paused to look at Catra, "Hi," she said more mutedly, nodding in her direction. She hoped she didn't look like she'd just been undressing her with her eyes. Though she was the first to admit she had no poker face.

"Hey Adora," Catra said in a way that felt more human than ever before. Maybe even flirty? Nah. That was highly doubtful.

Bow explained that he invited Catra and Scorpia; they'd all become friends when he started volunteering at BAWS. Which makes sense but come on! There was already too much real estate taken up by Catra in her head. Especially after their last conversation last week when she thanked her for helping.

Before she could sit down, the whole crew stood up to go to the bar. All except Catra.

Scorpia turned to her, "Wildcat, want anything?"

"Don't call me that," Catra said, but there was no fire in it, "I'll take a gin and tonic. Thanks, Scorp."

And then there was two. Glimmer turned around to look at Adora before she disappeared into the crowd. She wiggled her eyebrows suggestively. Adora shook head. Glimmer had the maturely level of a 12-year-old, and with a little bit of alcohol in her system, she had zero filters to contain herself. She hoped Catra hadn't seen that.

They sat there in silence. Adora took a big sip of her Green Crush. This is going to be very painful. With four people getting drinks at a crowded bar, it would take forever for them all to return. She could be stuck there with the hot asshole for an eternity. She gave herself a pep talk. She could do this! She could sit there in silence. After all, she had nothing specific to say. Catra wasn't exactly a friend. Nope. She was not going to be the first to speak.

Five seconds later.

"So how are the 16 new cats doing?" Adora asked, apparently unable to control herself. She couldn't deal with the silence. But she did manage to look at Catra directly for a response.

Catra had been scrolling through her phone this whole time. She seemed completely unbothered by their lack of conversation. She slowly glanced up and looked back at her.

"Ah, great actually. Five cats have already been adopted, three have left to the cat café, two have been put in medical isolation while they recover from surgery. The remaining cats are in the general room. I guess you'll see them tomorrow."

Adora blinked. Aside from orientation, this might be the longest she'd heard Catra speak. It was really nice. She liked the sound of her voice. It was a little raspy and unfortunately made Catra even more attractive. Sadly, Glimmer was right, just because Catra was an ass, doesn't mean she wasn't interested in her.

"Oh great, I'm looking forward to meeting them." Adora responded finally. "I like cats." I like cats! Did she really just say that out loud. Wait, how did Catra remember she was volunteering tomorrow? Did Scorpia tell her? Did she look on the calendar? Either way, it was surprising. She still felt awkward and continued to feel the need to fill the silence. She cleared her throat.

"So how long have you worked at BAWS?"

"Going on three years."

"Nice. You must like it."

"I do."

Two words response. Catra didn't offer anything else and didn't bother asking her any questions. Adora internally gave an eye roll. Okay, so it was going to be a one-sided conversation. Adora took another sip of her drink. Mermista was very talented. She could barely taste the gin. She would definitely be getting a second.

"My drink has gin in it." She offered stupidly, shaking her head at the ridiculous statement.

Catra looked at her with confusion.

"You ordered a G&T, so I think you might like my drink." Adora looked at her, Catra's expression was flat, no reaction, so she kept

on babbling, “Though it’s kind of healthy and you can’t really taste the gin,” she added.

“What the drink?”

“It’s called ‘Green Crush.’ Mermista, the bartender, is a friend. She made it for me. It has random stuff in it. I think grapefruit and spinach. And some other green things. Honestly, I just drink whatever she makes me.”

“Good friend.”

“The best.”

More silence. Adora looked around the bar. She knew it pretty well. She’d been there plenty of times till closing, so she’d see it empty and full too many times to count. And she’d never been more uncomfortable there then she was right now. She turned back to Catra who was looking casually at her nails. They were shortish and seemed perfectly manicured with meticulously painted black. Adora thought about her nails. They were always cut short both as a matter of preference, and her job. But also, frankly as a queer woman it felt like a part of her uniform. But she never bothered to paint them. She would almost always chip off the paint in annoyance within a day.

“Ah, want to try it?” Offering her the drink to taste. Was she really still talking about this cocktail? Stop it Adora.

“Sure.” Catra said slowly, a little surprised by the offer. Adora handed her the drink. Their fingers touching briefly as Catra took it from her. Adora followed the movements of the glass to Catra’s mouth where she took a small sip. Her perfect mouth forming a seal around the edge. She kept looking as Catra licked slightly at remnants of drink on her lips. Adora wondered if the bar just got really hot or was watching Catra’s mouth giving her have a minor stroke?

“It’s good.” Catra said, pushing the glass back to her. Catra’s voice snapped her out of the staring, her eyes quickly moved up

face, away from her lips. Could she be more obvious and embarrassing. She could feel the heat in her cheeks. Did Catra notice her staring?

“I like it too.” Enough about the drink Adora! Maybe she needed a little distance away from this woman.

“I’m a…I’m going to the bathroom,” she announced abruptly. She stood up quickly and hurried to the other side of the bar towards the bathroom with the drawing of a mermaid on it. Could this be more mortifying! She could lift an entire firehose by herself, respond to medical emergencies, she could even carry grown adults over her shoulder out of a burning building to safety but somehow sitting across from this one person she became completely inept and incapable of having simple small talk.

She went to the sink and put the cold tap on. She splashed water on her face to cool herself down. She looked in the mirror and gave herself another pep talk. “You got this, you are smart and competent. You can get through one happy hour with this woman.”

She heard the door open behind her as someone came in. She immediately stopped talking to herself. She heard the lock to the door turn, very odd. The footsteps stopped behind her and she inhaled when she saw Catra’s reflection in the mirror in front of her.

“Hey Adora.” Catra said to her, her voice seemed huskier than before. “You okay?”

“Yep.” She said to Catra’s reflection. Why had she locked the door?

“You ran in here pretty quickly, so I wanted to check.” She wanted to check on her. That’s interesting. And surprising.

Adora turned around to face her. Making eye contact, “Yeah, I’m fine.” She swallowed and then blurted. “To be honest, you make me a little uncomfortable.” Why did she say that out loud!?

“I do?” She stepped closer to Adora.

She cleared her throat, “You do.”

Catra stepped a little closer. Adora’s breath hitched. She was only a foot away and it was too close for her comfort. Why was she standing so close? Why had she locked the door?!

“How about now?” What was she doing? Adora had to assume she’d either lost her mind or Catra was definitely flirting with her.

“Um.”

“Now?” Catra she took another small step; she was a breath away now. She put her hands on the counter behind Adora, forcing her to lean backwards against it to maintain the few inches of distance between.

Adora’s breath caught, her mind started spinning. She did not fully compute what was happening. Why was Catra doing this? This went beyond flirting. This was…definitely more.

She decided to stop thinking and get out of her own way. She blinked up at Catra, looking her in the eyes for some confirmation, some consent. Whatever she saw there gave her the push she needed. She closed the distance between them and kissed her. It was not a tentative kiss, it a hungry wanting kiss. The kiss she’d been fantasizing about since she’d first saw her at BAWS if she were honest with herself. Her lips clung to Catra’s, her arms moving around her, pushing the two of them closer together. To her credit, this was clearly what Catra was trying to get her to do because she responded with just as much hunger, opening her mouth to Adora and tasting her for the first time. Adora moaned into her mouth. This felt amazing and she tasted so good. A little like the Green Crush. That thought made her smile.

“What?” Catra whispered against her mouth.

“Nothing.” She paused, “You taste like Green Crush.”

Catra groaned a little, burying her nose in Adora's neck, inhaling her. "You are such a dork. No more cocktail talk." She chastised.

"Fair," Adora said with a little smirk. And with that, she picked up Catra like she weighed nothing, flipping them around and sitting her on the sink counter, crushing their mouths together again. She slipped her tongue in Catra's mouth, continuing to take whatever she was willing to give. Catra moved her legs around Adora waist. Adora responded by grabbing Catra's ass, pushing her even closer together against her hips. She needed her as close as possible, wanted to feel every inch of her body on top of her own.

"A little eager, are we?" Catra laughed.

Adora looked up into her eyes, trying to read her. Did she want to stop? Is this too much?

"I didn't say you should stop," Catra said, reading her mind.

Adora smiled and brought her mouth back down. This time she slowed the kiss. The hunger was still there, as was the eagerness, but now she took her time. Really savoring this moment. It was more sensual somehow. She allowed herself to explore Catra's mouth, the soft lips she had been staring at before, the curves. She gave them a little nibble. For a first kiss, they fit incredibly well. They both knew what the other might wanted, or maybe they both liked the same things. Adora moved a hand to Catra's hair, she'd been dying to touch it since they'd first met. It felt soft and thick. The curly tendrils like soft cotton against her fingers. She gently grabbed it to tilt her face up so she could get a better angle. Even with Catra on the sink, Adora was a few inches taller than her. Catra gave a small growl in satisfaction. They continued to kiss like they never needed to come up for air. Little moaning sounds escaped Catra's mouth which made Adora groan with pleasure. She tasted and sounded so good. She wondered what the rest of her tasted like. She wanted to produce more beautiful moans from her. She trailed kisses down to her neck, the soft sensitive spot an inch or two below her ears. Adora alternated between kissing and softly sucking her skin. Running her tongue

against sweet and salty taste of her. Catra moaned again, throwing her head back in pleasure. Adora could spend forever just against this part of her body. Catra moved a finger to her chin so she could kiss her again, wanting to bring their lips together again. Pure bliss.

After what seemed like forever, but was probably only a few minutes, they pulled apart.

Adore was panting and flushed, her lips a little bruised. She saw Catra's mouth was very red as well.

They both looked at each other, eyes wide.

Adora's brain turned back on and it was running quickly, too quickly. How did this happen? Catra had given her no indication she was interested in her. Sure, she had probably been a little too obvious, but she didn't think the attraction was mutual. What did this mean?

It was, of course, Adora who spoke first, "I. I didn't think you liked me very much."

Catra looked up at her with a little rueful smile, "You're such an idiot."

Interesting response. But it was enough to make Adora feel more confident.

"Oooh, I see. So then you *do* like me."

Catra shook her head with a throaty laugh and gave her a quick peck on her lips, "This is not because I like you." Adora laughed back.

Behind them, the doorknob turned, and they heard the lock on the door catching. Adora looked at Catra, eyes wide with fear, Catra laughed.

“It’s locked Adora. But I guess it’s time we went back to the table.”

Adora groaned, fuck. The table, their friends! She had no poker face. They’d all know, or at least Glimmer and Perfuma would. She stepped away from Catra who smoothly jumped down from the sink and went to unlock the door. Whoever had tried to open it earlier had thankfully given up.

“Um, should we go back separately?” Adora asked tentatively.

“Whatever you want, Princess.” She guessed that nickname is still alive and well.

Catra left the bathroom first. Adora looked at her disheveled face in the mirror and gave herself a different pep talk. “You are both consenting adults, you can do whatever and whomever you want with,” that statement only served to make her blush more. She shook her head; she was making herself crazy. She stood up a little more confidently, looked herself in the eye and finished the pep talk, “and it’s no one’s business.”

When she returned to the table a few minutes later, everyone was seated and laughing. No one gave her return a second thought. Glimmer was telling them about her work in the communications office of State Senator Huntara. Catra looked up at her and gave a quick nod, casual, as if nothing happened between them. Adora’s drink was still sitting on the table, the condensation saturating the napkin it was on.

“So, I told her, you can’t be without a social media presence in the 21st century. You must be on twitter, instagram, facebook and frankly, I’d even suggest tiktok if you want to attract a younger demographic. So that’s basically how I went from being an intern to social media specialist a few months ago.” Glimmer shrugged casually, like her huge job promotion wasn’t that big of a deal.

“What did your mother say when you told her,” Bow asked, eyes wide open in admiration.

“She was proud, I think. I know she didn’t want me to pursue a political career but how could I help myself! She is a US Senator, Dad used to be the secretary of Veteran Affairs. Did she think I was going to become a dentist? Politics is in our blood. Plus, it’s awesome! I love it.” Glimmer was grinning. She loved talking about her work.

Scorpia jumped in, “Wow, that is so neat Glimmer! It sounds like you like you might be running for office one day soon.” Glimmer smiled at the compliment. Scorpia turned shyly towards Perfuma, “What do you do for work?”

“Me?” Perfuma politely demurred, “Nothing special. I work in a vegan organic co-op. I manage the green house in the back. Most of the greens we sell come from there.”

“Wow, that sounds amazing! You must have a green thumb. It is no wonder you look so good - ” Scorpia turned a lovely shade of red, “- I mean. What I meant is you look healthy.” Scorpia got flustered and embarrassed. Not sure where to look, finally looking down at her hands.

“That’s so kind Scorpia.” Perfuma responded, in no way upset about the compliment. “I appreciate it.”

Scorpia looked back up, a little less flustered and gave Perfuma a big smile.

Glimmer and Adora exchanged knowing grins. This was adorable. Seems there were a few love connections happening tonight.

Adora was enjoying the conversations at the table but she was distracted sitting so close to Catra. Only a few minutes ago, Catra’s legs had been wrapped around her, Adora’s tongue in her mouth, fingers in her hair, hands on her ass. Who knows what would have happened between them if someone hadn’t tried to get into the bathroom? She flushed at the thoughts of what if

fantasies flooding her mind. She had the ghost of Catra on her skin and in her mouth and she wanted more. Yet she was sitting across from her, politely listening to their friends and she had no ability to truly concentrate on what anyone was saying. She found herself absentmindedly finishing her drink without really tasting it. She would definitely need another. She rose and asked if anyone wanted anything at the bar. No one needed a refresh quite yet.

"I'll come with you," Catra offered.

Adora nodded casually. Like this was normal. She and Catra traveling in a pack to the bar. The thirty second walk to the bar felt longer. The tension of walking near Catra made her heart race. The bar was very crowded when the approached, and it took a while for Mermista to notice them.

"Um, what do you want," Adora asked, looking at Catra's. She had to lean in to ask because of how loud it was.

Catra smirked. Adora realized how the question could be interpreted. "Another gin and tonic," she practically shouted back so Adora could hear her. Their faces were very close. Adora's heart rate did not slow down.

Adora reluctantly turned around to lean over the bar to try to get Mermista's attention. Catra stood behind her, putting her hand casually on the small of her back. Adora swallowed at the touch.

Mermista finally noticed her and sauntered over.

"Hi Beautiful, you're back to see me again? I knew you couldn't stay away." Mermista winked and suggestively bent over so Adora could see her beautiful cleavage. Her brown skin glistening from the heat of the bar.

Adora cleared her throat, Mermista's flirting felt a little different now with Catra behind her. Should she introduce her? I guess she would it if it were anyone else.

"Hi M," she said, a blush forming. "Um, this is my … friend, Catra."

“Why hello friend, Catra.” She said in greeting. “What can I get you hot stuff?”

Adora rolled her eyes. She never let up! “I’ll take more of that Green Crush please and she’ll have a G&T.”

“It will be my pleasure to serve you.” Mermista smiled suggestively and started to go make the drinks.

Catra removed her hand from her back. Its absence made Adora disappointed. She wanted that hand back on her body.

Adora turned around to look at her. Catra had stepped back and was looking around. Not making eye contact.

Mermista returned, “Here you are. G&T and a Green Crush. Enjoy.”

“Thanks M, can you put it on my tab.”

“Sure thing,” she winked again and walked away. It was more of a sashay then a walk.

Adora handed the drink to Catra.

“How much do I owe you.” Catra asked stiffly.

“Don’t worry about it, it’s on me.” Adora responded with a smile.

“No, that’s okay. I’d like to pay.” Adora’s smiled stiffened. She could feel a shift between them. Like somehow Catra had snapped out of whatever bubble they had been in together and she didn’t know why. What happened?

“Um. Seriously it’s okay. Its happy hour, I think it was only five bucks. You’re not putting me out.”

Catra nodded mutely. Whatever happened between them in the bathroom never happened.

They returned to the table and Adora felt Catra retreating into herself. She finished her G&T pretty quickly, whispered something to Scorpia and started to stand up to leave.

“Are you heading out, Catra?” Bow asked, surprised.

“Yeah. I have to take care of some stuff tonight.” She gave a quick tilt of her mouth, it almost resembled a smile, except it didn’t reach her eyes. “Thanks for the invite Bow. It was nice meeting you all.” She said politely, not looking Adora in the eye. She disappeared in the crowd quickly after.

Adora wanted to walk out with her, to ask her what happened. It was strange to feel very connected to a person who she knew almost nothing about and yet somehow also felt intimately in tune with. She didn’t even have her phone number. She didn’t even know her last name! The incredibly hot moment they shared never happened. Maybe she made it up. She knew she hadn’t. But Catra’s confusing behavior tonight was worse than when she was being an asshole. When she was an asshole, she could just dislike her, even with the insane attraction. Tonight, she became a real person. Someone who had a real connection with, albeit a physical one. Adora couldn’t think of anyone she’d been with that she’d had this type of chemistry with. She craved more. And whatever happened with Catra tonight made it seem like that might never happen.

Tomorrow’s volunteer work would certainly be interesting.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you enjoyed reading this as much as I enjoyed writing it.

I added the cocktail recipe to the previous chapter notes, and it's here as well if you'd like to make it at home: https://dietitiandebbie.com/green-juice-cocktail/

As always, comments are my virtual Nutella. Newbie Tumblr account @enigm17a

Shadow

Chapter Notes

> Seems I'm doing Sunday/Wednesday updates. I have two more chapters fully written so hopefully I can keep up this schedule...don't hold me to it though.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The next day, Adora felt anxious before she even got to BAWS. She wanted to see Catra, wanted to talk to her, but she was also was nervous. Catra wasn't someone she felt at ease around. With the notable exception of the bathroom, she didn't know how to act around her or what to say to her. Her behavior last night was very strange. She seemed so into her one moment and then completely cold the next. It didn't make sense. Adora couldn't put it out of her head. It made it very difficult to concentrate today. She had to tuck Catra into her back pocket and only pull her out on her way to BAWS. As she rode Swift Wind, she thought back to her phone conversation with Glimmer late last night.

"Well! What did you think?" Glimmer asked excitedly.

"Of what?"

"Of us, of Bow and me. How did we seem? How was our *energy?*" Adora chuckled to herself. Glimmer had been spending too much time with Perfuma. Adora was the last person to notice someone's energy. But she'd play along.

"You two were very cute, it was clear you have a connection. Plus, I really like Bow. I'm invested in this one!"

"Me too! He is pretty great, isn't he? And those abs of his!" Glimmer whistled, "I had no idea I would be so attracted to a man in a middrift top." She gushed. Clearly smitten.

“I mean, what’s not to like?” Adora chuckled. “He’s cute, he’s smart, so nice and he loves animals. I’m so glad it’s going so well between you both.”

“I really like him.” Glimmer seemed thoughtful. And happy. “I think I’ll keep him” Adora smiled. Glimmer continued, “Okay topic change. Did you see how adorable Scorpia was with Perfuma?”

“Shh, she’ll hear you!” Adora scolded.

“Nah, she’s not home yet.”

“What do you mean? You didn’t go home together tonight?”

“Nope. Bow and I decided to hang out a little after, so Scorpia offered to take her home.” Glimmer said.

“Wow, that was hours ago!” Adora said, surprised.

“Yup! If she were with someone else who she’d just met I might be more concerned. But from what you and Bow have said, Scorpia is harmless.”

“Scorpia is an absolutely sweetheart. But I’m still a bit surprised.”

“For sure! But I’m so glad for Perfuma. She hasn’t been interested in someone in a while.” Glimmer paused, as if formulating how to phrase her next thought, “So. Catra.”

“What about her?”

“She is freaking hot. Damn! I can see why you’ve been obsessed with her.”

“I have not been obsessed.” Adora rolled her eyes, but her heart rate picked up a little.

“Sure, whatever you say. So, spill! What happened tonight?”

“What do you mean?” Adora’s voice got an octave higher.

“Adora.” She said reprouchflully, huffing through the phone. Adora could almost see her eye roll through the phone.

“Glimmer.” Adora replied innocently.

“Please don’t make me point out the obvious.”

“And what would that be?”

“We all went to the bar, when we came back, you were both gone! Where did you go? Was she helping you with your taxes or something? And then A LOT of time passed and you both skulked back to the table. I mean. I don’t know Catra, so I don’t *actually* know if she was skulking, but you definitely were. And you were a mess! Your hair was a mess, you face was a mess. And you barely said a word the rest of the night.”

Adora paused. She guessed all of that was true. She thought they had gotten away with it. She hadn’t planned on saying anything. But she was kind of dying to talk to someone about what happened. She had just hoped to process on her own a little bit first.

She cleared her throat before responding. “Um. We might have made out a little in the bathroom.”

“You WHAT!” Glimmer practically screamed through the phone.

“Shh, you’ll blow out my ears.” She laughed. She knew Glimmer would flip out.

“I’m sorry, what! How did you go from barely speaking to making out in the bathroom? Not that it’s bad, but I’m genuinely curious.”

“Honestly, I don’t know. You all left, and we had the most awkward small talk at the table. I could barely formulate sentences. It was highly embarrassing. I left to go to the bathroom, and she followed me. And then it just happened. It was not premediated.”

“Wow, I am damned proud of you for getting yours. But I’m a little surprised. We both know this isn’t your first bathroom hook ups, but typically it’s with someone you don’t know and frankly, have no interest in.”

“I know. That’s the strange part. With her, I’m inept. I don’t know how to act, what to say, what to do with my hands, where to look! She is so damn beautiful, but her behavior is so strange. Yet somehow, in the bathroom, things felt so right and easy with her. The chemistry was so strong. And then –,” Adora snapped her fingers, “- poof, it was gone. She went from hot to cold so quickly. And I have no idea why.”

“Hmm. That’s strange. I mean you said she was a bit of an odd duck before.”

“Yeah, but this felt different. One minute she was touching me with so much familiarity, and then the next she was robotically asking to pay for her own drink. I’m still reeling.” Adora explained, exasperated remembering it all. She just didn’t understand what could have happened. They had this amazing physical connection and then poof. It was gone!

“I’m sorry Adora, that does sound odd. But you’ll see her at BAWS tomorrow, right? Are you going to say anything?”

“Should I?”

“I guess that depends on what you want. Do you want to have some sort of relationship with her? Friendship or otherwise?”

Adora thought about it for a second and knew without a doubt the answer was yes. “I do.”

“That’s kind of exciting, Adora. I don’t think I’ve ever heard you express an interest in anyone before. I think you have to talk to her.”

Adore let out a deep exhale. She was not great at this sort of thing and frankly didn’t have a lot of experience with actual

relationships. She didn't care to have romantic entanglements, much preferring the occasional hook up with a stranger. She didn't have the interest in maintaining the emotional labor of a relationship. When she craved intimacy and physical touch, she got it and moved on quickly. Figuring things out with Catra, she already knew, would take work. Actual emotional work.

"I guess you're right."

"I know I'm right. And if you see Bow tomorrow, can you swat his ass for me?" Glimmer asked.

"What! No!"

Glimmer laughed.

"Fine fine. I'll do it myself. Goodnight friend. Good luck tomorrow."

She would need it.

She felt a little more determined as she took off her helmet and locked up Swift Wind near the entrance of BAWS. She would try to talk to her. But also, this was Catra's workplace. She didn't want to dredge things up for her at work. She signed. This was getting a little complicated. She needed to remind herself she was ultimately here to volunteer and help animals.

She dropped of her stuff in the cubby, washed her hands and made her way to the cat area. She passed Catra's office door on the way. It was closed but she could see her typing furiously through the glass, looking pensive. She didn't look like she wanted to be interrupted. Maybe she would have her door open later. She looked at the name on the door, Catra Horde. At least now she knew her last name. She gave a sad little chuckle. She started to go through the daily tasks for the cats. Cleaning their cages, freshening up their water and food, scooping their litter boxes. Giving them cuddles. She was getting pretty good in this role. It made her happy to be able to give them a little bit of love. BAWS

did a great job taking care of the animals but ultimately, they were still in cages, without access to comfy couches to curl up on or cat trees to jump onto to. If she made even an ounce of different in their lives, she was glad to.

As she went through each cage, she could feel her resolve weaken. Maybe she shouldn't try to talk to Catra at work. It was kind of inappropriate and she did look super busy. Maybe she could ask Scorpia for Catra's number and she could send her a text instead. No. That's probably weird to do. It wasn't right to involve Scorpia and frankly it wasn't her number to give out. Adora started to get more and more conflicted with this train of thought. If she didn't talk to her at work, and she didn't have a way to contact her outside of work, does that mean she'd never talk to her at all. Perhaps that was best. Maybe she should pretend the bathroom never happened. This was already more effort than she'd normally put into a woman.

She let out an exasperated "Ug" out loud. The cute striped cat she was holding looking at her, startled.

"Sorry kitty, didn't mean to scare you." The cat cocked his head as if sizing her up. Finally, he headbutted her in forgiveness. Asking her for ear scratches. She was happy to oblige.

She was down to one last cage. The name on the cage said Shadow. And she could see why, this cat was mostly dark grey but had darker black fur around her neck. Her face looked like a mask with black rings surrounding her eyes. Very interesting coloring. Based on the note on her cage, the cat was found wondering the streets of Etheria. The cat snarled at her before she had even opened the cage. Uh Oh. This might be a little tricky. She had a bad feeling about this cat. She slid her fingers into the holes of the door so Shadow could familiarize herself with Adora's scent. The cat was not interested. She looked at Adora's fingers as if they offended her. If cats could look haughty, that would be the look on this cat's face. Shadow slowly retreated to the back of the cage, pupils' sharp green slits, ears flat, tail low. Adora was no expert but this definitely looked like pre-pounce behavior. Adora

bit her lip. Managing this cat might be a little above her paygrade. Maybe she should get help? She looked down the hall and debated finding Scorpia or maybe Catra. She shook her head. No. She could do this. This was just a cat. How hard could this be!

She came back and took a deep breath. They could sense fear, right? Or was that dogs? Either way. Being calm would serve her best.

She slowly opened the cage with one hand and quickly pulled out the litter box. Success! She scooped it clean and just as quickly reinserted it in the cage. Shadow was watching her every movement. Calculated eyes followed her. She managed to swap out the water dish without incident. Okay! One final step. Food dish. Easy. She's got this. She managed to slip it out of the cage and refilled it. Almost done! She slowly opened the cage to place it back inside and that's when Shadow decided it was time to defend her turf. She flew at Adora, wrapping her sharp claws into her shoulder and biting her neck. Kibble spilled everywhere. The food dish fell from her hand, bouncing off the floor with a very loud clang.

"Ouch!" Adora cried out loudly, startled and in pain. She had clearly underestimated Shadow and the cat was not looking like she was ready to stop. She was out to destroy her intruder, and nothing could derail her. She was making high pitched noises, ready to show Adora who was boss. Adora shut her eyes tight from the pain, while simultaneously trying to extricate Shadow's claws from out of her shoulder. She heard rushed footsteps behind her.

"Help," she managed to croak out to whoever just entered the room.

"It's okay, you're okay," she heard Catra say calmly to the cat, almost in a whisper. Adora opened her eyes and saw Catra slowly petting Shadow on her neck. Trying to calm her down so she could help remove her from Adora's body. Shadow hissed at them both, but slowly, too slowly, loosed her grip on Adora. Catra gently

put her back in her cage, making sure the door was securely locked before she turned to look at Adora.

"You're hurt." Catra said, thankfully not bothering to say something stupid like 'are you okay?'

She could feel her neck pulsing from where Shadow bit her. Her shoulder was also tender. But despite the pain, she was a little shell shocked at seeing Catra again. Keeping her face neutral she calmly responded.

"A little, yes."

"Okay, let's go get you cleaned up." Catra gestured for Adora to follow her. As they walked away, Shadow launched herself at the cage door, clearly unhappy they got away. Vowing to get her revenge.

They made their way to the clinic at the back of BAWS. Catra asked her to sit down so she could look at the damage.

"Wow, she really got you good huh."

Catra wet some gauze and started to clean out the bite on her neck. Dabbing at it very gently to try to clean it without further irritating her. Adora wondered whether she should stop her, offer to do it herself. She was an EMT after all, this was very minor flesh wound. But she couldn't speak having Catra so close to her. Feeling her fingers on this very sensitive part of her body almost made her shudder. She willed herself not to move. Her position in the chair also meant Catra's chest was right next to face every time she approached. Her intoxicating scent, faintly smelling of honey walnut soap, invading her nose. She swallowed and willed herself into silence. Finally satisfied it was clean enough, Catra dried the wound, and put a little antiseptic cream on top, covering it with sterile dressing.

"May I?" Catra asked, gesturing to Adora's shoulder, needing to access her bare skin to evaluate the scratches.

Adora mutely nodded. She was wearing a blue button-down short sleeved cuffed shirt, over a white racer-back compression shirt. She unbuttoned the shirt and took it off the affected shoulder. She could have sworn she heard Catra inhale quickly as she watched her remove it. Adora always wore the compression shirt on days she worked out or went to the firehouse. It was very comfortable under her fireman's uniform. It left her arms unrestrained and provided additional support for her chest, picking up the slack from her overworked sports bra. It also showed off her strong muscles if she was being honest. Even when she wasn't flexing, her arms were beautifully toned, showing the years of careful conditioning. Ripped would be the word Glimmer would use.

Catra cleared her throat and gently moved the shirt strap and sports bra off Adora's shoulder. She looked intently at her collarbone. Adora had never thought much at her clavicle before, but with Catra looking so long, she started feeling warm. Exposed. And more than a little turned on. She swallowed.

The damage wasn't so bad there. She had the two layers of clothes to protect her from Shadow's claws, unlike her neck. After a long examination Catra finally cleaned and dried the area without needing to dress it.

"Okay, I think you're all set. Watch out for signs of infection okay?"

"Um, thanks," Adora adjusted the sports bra and undershirt back onto her shoulder with a wince. That's going to be uncomfortable for a few days. Adding a fun element to her work.

Catra was looking at her. Like she wanted to say something but wasn't sure what or maybe didn't know how. Adora decided it was time to be a little brave.

"I appreciate you saving me from the cat intent on destroying me." Adora smiled warmly, trying to re-build report with the enigmatic woman. "Also, I…I'm really glad you decided to come to the bar yesterday. I really enjoyed spending time together." She

could feel her entire face (and probably her neck and chest) flush. Which with her shirt unbuttoned was painfully obvious. "I was disappointed you decided to head out early." Should she ask why her mood suddenly shifted? She wasn't sure how to ask that so instead she added sweetly, looking her directly in the eye, "I had hoped to spend more time with you." She willed herself to be a little vulnerable and didn't look away.

Catra had been looking at her while she spoke but now looked away, not wanting to meet her eyes. She seemed to be composing her thoughts. Adora forced herself to sit in the silence and wait.

Finally, after what seemed like a lifetime, Catra said, "I enjoyed spending time together too." She paused here, looking down at her hands and then looking at Adora, "I guess I didn't realize; I mean... I would be down to hang out again."

Hmm. Didn't realize what? What does hang out mean? But she'll wonder about that later. She said she wanted to hang out again! Small victory.

"Really?!" Adora practically squealed.

Catra broke out in a surprised chortle. "Yes, really."

"Great!" Not wanting Catra to change her mind, Adora reached into her back pocket to grab her phone. "What's your number, I'll text you and you'll have mine."

Catra looked like she might change her mind. She hesitantly gave Adora her digits; looking like she regretted doing so as soon as the words came out of her mouth.

Adora wasted no time in saving her number and sending Catra an introductory text.

Adora:
Hi! This is Adora. From BAWS.

She inserted a cat and dog emoji in case BAWS was somehow unclear.

Catra pulled her phone of her jeans pocket. Looked down and shook her head.

"You're such a dork."

Adora grinned like she had just been given the biggest compliment. Yup. She was a proud card-carrying dork. And jock. And queer.

Catra:
Hi Adora. From BAWS.

Adora laughed reading the text.

"How many 'Adoras' do you think I know." Catra asked seriously.

"Um. Good point. Three?"

Catra gave her short throaty laugh. "Okay Princess, if you think you've recovered enough from your battle, I have to go back to work."

Adora looked at her with a frown on her brow, "But it's almost 5 now, how much longer were you planning on working tonight?"

Catra signed a little, ruffling her hair in frustration. "Honestly, I don't know. We're having some unexpected budget issues that I need to look into, so we shall see."

Adora considered this. Budgets weren't her specialty, but she realized that a nonprofit like BAWS must struggle in a way that all nonprofits do.

“I’m sorry, that sounds very stressful. I wish I could help.”

Catra cocked a little half smile, “Thanks. If you come up with a way for us to raise 10K in 8 weeks, let me know.”

“Wow, that much.”

“Yep. Unfortunately, we didn’t get the grant we were relying on getting and that’s throwing everything off kilter. If we don’t get this money, it’s going to seriously affect our daily operations this year.”

That was stressful. Adora wished she could figure out a way to do something.

“I’m sorry Catra, if I think of anything I can do to help, I’ll definitely let you know.”

“Yeah, thanks. Hey, before you head out, can you find Scorpia and tell her what happened with Shadow. She’s going to need some extra rehabilitation before she can become adoptable.”

“I’d say so! She was really out for blood. She was ready to declare war.” A thought came to her and she was a little hesitant to ask it but here goes, “Catra. What happens to the cats that don’t become adoptable?” She wasn’t sure she wanted to know; it made her sad to consider the options.

“It depends. Some cats are not great in homes but can become barn cats or mousers. People will adopt them to help maintain rodent populations. That way they don’t have to socialize with humans but are still well taken care of.”

“Oh wow, that’s pretty cool.”

“I think so too.” Catra smiled at her. A real genuine smile for the first time today. It made Adora warm and fuzzy. She smiled back. Fuck. She was fucked. This was definitely not just a physical attraction anymore. There was something else here. Something real. She wondered if Catra felt it too.

Chapter End Notes

Thoughts? Concerns? Suggestions? I like the idea of making Shadow weaver an angry cat. She'd make an excellent mouser.

As always, comments are my virtual Nutella. Newbie Tumblr account @enigm17a

Emily

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The next day, Adora woke up bright and early to go to work, arriving at the fire station at 6am for her 7am shift dressed in her uniform. She arrived with donuts and coffee for both her shift crew and for the crew that was clocking out. She almost always brought snacks in the morning. She was still a rookie and the department's first female firefighter; she was hyper focused on making a good impression on the veteran staff, and frankly wasn't above buying their love with food. She put away her personals in her locker, set up the food and sat down with a cup of coffee to catch a breath and momentarily closer her eyes. She'd been up since 4:30am and she didn't realize how tired she was till this moment. All last night, she couldn't get Catra, ahem, no not Catra, BAWS out of her mind. On nights before her 24-hour shifts, she liked to go to bed early, but thinking about Catra, crap!, no, BAWS, kept her up later than normal. She wished could do something to help with their financial shortfall. Being a foster child for the latter half of her childhood, Adora didn't grow up with money and just took for granted she'd never make a lot of it given her chosen profession, she had no clue how they could raise so much money in such a short period of time. She should ask Glimmer. She came from the world of trust funds and politics; she had attended many a gala fundraiser in her day, she would probably have some good ideas.

After breakfast, Adora spent time cleaning the common areas. As a rookie, unless she was eating, sleeping, or fighting a fire, she was expected to always be busy; that meant when she wasn't working on the rig, studying the fire manuals, she was helping to clean the station. Passing the common room bulletin board, she chuckled. Some local EMTs had done a calendar photo shoot to raise money for the local elementary school; they were posed with little kids dressed in EMT uniforms performing "life saving

measures” on the EMT crew. It was both hilarious and adorable. It always made Adora chuckle. There was nothing cuter than little kids in costumes. Wait! Not true! One thing was definitely cuter. BAWS should do a calendar! Who wouldn’t want to buy a calendar with cute local shelter animals?

Adora looked around before pulling out her phone. She always felt nervous someone would yell at her for texting or making personal calls, even though everyone else in the station did it.

Adora:
Hey! I need to brainstorm something. You free?

Glimmer:
Sure, call me in five.

Adora walked to her bunk and called Glimmer.

“What’s up.”

“So, I had this idea, and I knew you’d be the right person to help me flush it out.”

“Shoot.”

“Catra mentioned that BAWS needs to raise 10K in 8 weeks or they’ll have to make significant operational cuts. What do you think of maybe doing a calendar of the BAWS animals as a fundraiser?”

“Hmm. I like the calendar idea, but you’d have to sell like 500 copies of the calendar to get anywhere close to that amount. I don’t think animals alone will sell that many. Plus, the cost to print them would eat into your profits.”

“Oh true,” those were all good points. Adora bit her lip. Oh well.

“But let me ponder a little more. I’ll let you know if I think of something.”

“Thanks Glimmer.”

“Always happy to help…the animals.”

“Why are you saying it like that?”

“Nothing, it’s just you haven’t told me how your talk with Catra went and now all of a sudden you’re helping her figure out fundraising.”

Adora could feel herself flushing. She cleared her throat, “Our talk was…good. Mostly. I’ll tell you about it later. I’m at work and the walls have ears. I’ll call you tomorrow. Or better yet, let’s do dinner.”

“Yes, we had better talk later! But I have dinner plans with Bow tomorrow.”

Adora smiled, someone was starting to spend a lot of time together. “That’s great. Tell him I say hello. We’ll talk another time then. Let me know if you get any ideas in the meantime.”

“Will do.”

Later that day, Adora got an image text from Glimmer. It was a doctored photo of Adora from the beach last summer. Adora was wearing red Hawaiian-print shorts and a black sports bra, her hair up in her signature poof. In the sun, her toned arms, strong legs and six pack abs were practically glistening. Adora looked damned good in anything showing off her body and Glimmer liked to remind her of that fact. Specifically, she called the picture her ‘thirst trap’ photo. She encouraged her to feature it her nonexistent dating profile, a suggestion Adora ignored. Glimmer had photoshopped a fireman’s hat on her head and a big goofy looking golden retriever by her legs.

Adora:
???

Glimmer:
Now this we could sell

Adora:
What? Photos of me at the beach?
I mean. I do look good there, but 500 copies good?

Glimmer:

Glimmer texted a rolling eye emoji

Pay attention Adora. You have to give the people what they want. And what they want is to see buff firefighters half naked, posing with cuddly animals.

Adora:
Ooooh. That's not a terrible idea. I wonder if I could get volunteers from the station. And from the other local Bright Moon stations!

Glimmer:
Yes. Talk to your captain, and I'm going to see what I can do to get the printing donated so it wouldn't eat into your profits.

Adora:
That would be amazing Glimmer! Okay, I'll see if I get the okay from the fire chief and I also need to run this by Catra.

Glimmer:
Yes. By all means, run it by your new buddy Catra. Maybe you can whisper the idea in her ear.

Adora:
I don't even know how to respond to that

Glimmer:
You also need a marketing plan. Maybe one that includes a strong

social media presence. Oh, and a photographer

Marketing plan? Social media presence. Photographer! Adora barely knew the password to her Instagram. This was getting a little over her head. Glimmer as if reading her mind, responded.

Glimmer:
Don't panic. I'm the social media queen. I can help with marketing so we can figure out how to sell these babies.

Adora:
Did I mention how much I love you.

Glimmer:
I mean. Not today.

Adora smiled. Glimmer was so good to her.

Adora:
Okay! Let's talk soon to see where we're at.

Glimmer:
Sounds like a plan.

Adora put away her phone and put on her brave face. This was a good idea. Maybe even a great idea. But she could only really execute it if had buy in from the veteran firefighters. Which meant she'd have to talk to her captain. She walked over to his office and knocked on the door. Captain Hordak was an intimidating figure. He was tall and strong and was known for his bravery when fighting fires. But he was also curt and hard to get to know. Adora never quite knew where she stood with him even months into her rookie year.

“Come in.”

“Hello Captain, do you have a moment?”

“Take a seat, Grayskull.” He gestured to a chair in front of his desk. Adora sat down and looked around momentarily. Most of his office was severe, no personal pictures or decoration. A few certificates of appreciation and his too modern office furniture. There was one notable exception. On his desk were two framed photos. One was of a beautiful woman with long purple pigtails. She was wearing industrial overalls with a welding mask on her head. She was happily smiling into the photo holding onto what looked like a massive welding gun. The other photo was of a reptile of some kind. She’d seen reptiles at BAWS but they made her a little wary, so she shied away from them. She knew almost nothing about them as pets.

Hordak must have noticed her looking because all of a sudden, this austere looking man, who normally wore his mouth in a thin flat line, started smiling broadly. “That’s Emily,” he proudly shared.

“She’s lovely,” Adora replied. Picking up the photo of the purple haired welder.

“No no, that’s my partner Entrapta.” Hordak laughed. The man laughs? Adora could barely keep up with all of this new information she was learning about her captain.

“Emily is our Bearded Dragon.” He proudly shared as if he was telling her about his offspring.

“Ooooh. Well, she’s also quite lovely.” Adora looked closer at the photo, “She actually looks like she’s smiling in this picture.”

“Doesn’t she!?” Hordak was practically gushing. “This was taken after we took a stroll in our backyard. She loves climbing trees.”

Adora tried to keep the confused look off her face. Stroll? Trees? She’d have to google Bearded Dragon’s later because it felt like he

was testing her somehow. Though his demeanor was definitely more doting then kidding.

"What can I do for you, Adora?" Hordak smiled at her. Like he was a real person! Adora was thrilled. This was a perfect segue.

"Yes, thanks for taking the time to speak with me. I've started volunteering at BAWS recently and learned that they are having some financial difficulties. I thought maybe we could do something to help."

"BAWS! We got Emily at BAWS last year. She was a rescue. Can you imagine someone abandoning that sweet girl?" Hordak shook his head in disbelief. Adora shook it alongside him. This conversation was revolutionary. She'd never look at Hordak the same again.

"Yes, it's so sad. But BAWS does such a great job finding caring forever homes like yours for the animals that come into the shelter. I thought maybe it would be fun to create a calendar featuring the animals from the shelter, with, um, some of the firefighters across Bright Moon."

"That would be fun! Maybe February could feature a bearded dragon! That's mine and Emily's birth month!" he exclaimed, clapping his hands together in excitement. Who was this man!

"What a lovely idea." Adora found herself agreeing without thinking. She couldn't say no to Hordak when he was this excited.

This was going so well! Should she push it and tell him about the 'thirst trap' angle Glimmer was thinking? He was in such a good mood now, it was now or never. "We were thinking, maybe the firefighters would pose in a…" Adora struggled with the phrasing, "um. Without their shirts. I mean, only if they were comfortable. That is. If that's okay. Um. For the animals. For the fundraiser. Sir." Well, that could have come out better.

"Oooh, like a bit of a provocative calendar. A little risqué." Hordak laughed happily. Like this was the funniest idea he'd ever heard.

Adora would have gladly never heard that word 'risqué' come out of her captain's mouth again if she could help it. But she started it. She had no one to blame but herself. And maybe Glimmer.

"Yes sir." She mumbled.

"What can Engine 17 do to help?"

"I was thinking that maybe if I composed an email invitation to audition for the calendar, you can send it out to the stations across Bright Moon so we could get some volunteers."

Hordak agreed to send out an email and even offered to bring it up at his next captains meeting. Adora was thrilled the meeting went so well and excited to tell Catra. Because it would help the animals. At BAWS. Which she wanted to support. Not because she needed a reason to talk to Catra. Or because she wanted Catra to be happy she was trying to help. Nope. All for the animals. The sweet cuddly animals.

Adora pulled out her phone again and spent a while staring at the screen before composing what was sure to be the best text ever. After a good five minutes, she wrote:

Adora:
Hi Catra

The three ellipses of death came and went. Adora kept staring at the screen, willing it to vibrate. Finally, a reply.

Catra:
Hey Adora

Adora didn't realize she had been holding her breath until she released it in relief.

Adora:
Do you have time to meet tomorrow? I have a fundraising idea for

BAWS I'd like to talk to you about

Catra:
When?

Adora:
I'm off tomorrow, so anytime works for me.

More ellipses. Then finally.

Catra:
Lunch?

Adora:
Sure. Let me know when and where and I'll meet you.

Adora's willed her heartrate to slow. Lunch was a meal. Friends shared meals together. This absolutely was not a date. She was meeting Catra to discuss the calendar idea. Which was friendly thing for her to do. She tried not to overthink it. She put away her phone and decided this would be a good time to go check the levels on the rig. Keeping her hands busy would hopefully keep her mind otherwise occupied. What she didn't realize, and no one was going to tell her, was she was grinning like a Cheshire cat as she opened the massive hood of the firetruck.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry this was more of a set up chapter. But I hope you enjoyed Hordak. I enjoyed deciding who Emily should be. And I spent waaaay too much time on youtube and amazon looking at bearded dragons and accessories. I've also spent a lot of time researching rookie life at a firestation and schedules. Even though probably no one but me is tracking it. I have a spreadsheet to keep track in case anyone wants to

see it. She's on a 'one day on, two day off' rotation. That one day is a full 24 hour day. Which means next week she will have to work on her BAWS volunteer day. Again, I'm sure no one needs to know this.

I hope you enjoyed the mental image of Adora at the beach.

Comments are my virtual Nutella :)

follow me on tumblr at enigm17a (thought again, I still don't know what I'm doing on there). Let me know if I should be following you.

Pie

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora biked up to the restaurant Catra had chosen for their lunch mtg. From the outside, it was small and non-descript. It almost blended into the two buildings alongside it. If you didn't know to look for it, you could easily miss it. It had a little wooden sign above the door with the name, "The Woods." Adora locked up Swift Wind and headed inside with her helmet. She was not nervous. She had no reason to be after all. This was not a date. And certainly, there was no reason to care what she looked like. Instinctively, she put a hand to her hair trying to smooth it out after wearing a helmet. She was a little early. Maybe she'd have time to run to the bathroom and take a look at herself before Catra arrived.

She entered the restaurant and was shocked to see how much bigger and nicer it looked on the inside. There were wooden beams on the ceiling. The walls were covered with murals of lush greenery and vines, giving the space a three-dimensional affect. Potted plants of all sizes lined the floors and walls. Pops of green carpet, made to look like grass, rounded up the décor. It almost looked like she was inside a cabin in the woods. She was grateful to see that Catra wasn't here yet. As she was looking around, she was greeted by a sweet older woman with a cloud of white hair and oversized purple glasses.

"Hello dearie, first time to the Woods?"

"Yes ma'am."

"Welcome, welcome, I'm Madame Razz. Sit wherever you like, and I'll come on over to take your order in a few minutes."

"Thank you, I'm waiting for a friend to join. Can I use your bathroom first?"

"Of course, dearie, just go down the hall and it'll be on your right."

Adora hustled to get into the bathroom. She was desperate to beat Catra to a table but really wanted to check herself out first. She looked in the mirror. Hair was decent enough, her face was a bit flushed from her ride, but otherwise she looked presentable. She gave her reflection a few finger guns, adding her favorite sound effects 'pew, pew, pew' and grinned at her idiocy. You look good, she told herself, trying to take a deep relaxing breath. She set her back straight. After another long moment evaluating herself in the mirror, she looked around the small single-stall bathroom. Only enough room in here for one. She flushed. Being in here definitely reminded her of the bathroom in Salineas. Catra on the sink, Catra's mouth against her neck, her hands against Catra's body…oh crap, this line of thought was dangerous. She shook her head, put a casual smile on her face and left quickly to find a table. She had just put her helmet on the seat next to her when Catra walked in.

Looking at Catra, Adora knew she was in trouble. There was nothing casual about the way Catra's appearance made her feel. Catra was wearing jeans with knee high boots, a tight maroon Henley shirt with the first two buttons open, her beautiful curly hair down around her shoulders. She looked so damned good and Adora had to use all her willpower to force her face back to a regular smile versus the gawking expression she was just wearing. She raised her hand and gave a little wave. Catra nodded and walked over, sliding in across from her in the small booth.

"Hey Adora," she said, her voice husky and familiar.

"Hiya Catra." She grinned a little too widely but tried to keep her gaze strictly to Catra's face. Above the two open buttons. Their slight height differential meant she had a good vantage point to her cleavage. Fuck.

She was grateful Madame Razz walked over to give them menus.

“Catra dearie! So good to see you again. Don’t stay away so long again.”

“Aww, did you miss me Razz?” Catra smiled but also looked a little chagrined. It was clear she really liked this woman. Adora found it utterly adorable.

“Of course, dearie! You know Madame Razz loves having you here. Do you want your usual?”

“Yes please!”

“Slice of double crusted chicken pot pie and a glass of iced mint tea, coming right up.” She turned to Adora, “How about you, dearie?” Adora hadn’t even had a chance to open the menu yet.

“Um. That actually sounds really good, I’ll have that as well. But with milk.”

“Good choice, dearie,” and with a quick grab of their menus, Madame Razz walked away to place their orders.

Catra looked at her expectedly, and Adora had to remind herself that this get together was her idea.

“Yes. Thanks for suggesting lunch. I was thinking about the financial situation at BAWS and I came up with a fundraising idea.” Catra raised an eyebrow and nodded for her to continue. “A BAWS calendar fundraiser, featuring Bright Moon firefighters.” Adora cleared her throat and looked just right of Catra’s face, not meeting her eye, a little embarrassed, “um you know, sexy firefighters.”

Catra’s throaty laugh brought Adora’s eyes back to Catra’s face.

“So, you’re suggesting that firefighters, excuse me, sexy firefighters, would pose with animals from BAWS, for a calendar”

“Yes, exactly.”

“Well, that’s definitely an idea. And you think that would get raise us a lot of money?”

“Honestly, I don’t know. Glimmer said she could try to find us someone who would donate the printing costs and she would help with promoting it, that’s something she’s really good at. We’d still need to find a photographer. Obviously, you would pick the featured animals and I would help us identify the firefighters. If we charge $20-$30 for each calendar, we will need to sell 300-500 copies to get to the goal. Which is a lot, but I think it may be possible!”

“You would identify the firefighters? You have a sexy firefighter connection?” Catra asked innocently. Adora flushed and was about to explain herself but then realized that Catra was teasing her. Her eyes were sparkling, her lips were edging upwards slightly.

“Bow mentioned you were a firefighter. That’s pretty awesome, Adora.”

Adora blushed both at the compliment and the fact that Catra used her name. Having her say it did something to her. “Yeah. Uh. Thanks. It was a lifelong dream of mine to do this kind of work.” Stop. She didn’t ask for your life story. Focus. “So, yeah. I talked to my chief and he said he’d send an email on my behalf to all the Bright Moon fire chiefs so we could get a decent number of volunteers to choose from. He also requested we feature a bearded dragon for the month of February.” She laughed. The conversation with Hordak was one for the books, she’d never get over how crazy it was.

“Bearded Dragon, how very specific,” Catra smiled, “I think we manage that. I’m pretty sure the lizard department has one or two up for adoption.”

“That’s great. He’ll be happy about that.” Adora smiled back. This was going well. Catra was here, outside of work. She didn’t seem angry or snarky. She was even kind of relaxed. And it was just the two of them. No animals to distract them or a loud bar. Definitely,

not a date. However, it was becoming crystal clear to Adora that she wanted it to be, or at least for there to be a future date with Ms. Catra Horde. That knowledge filled her both with a little thrill but also a little anxiety. She still didn't know what happened between them at Salineas. Catra ran hot and cold on her so quickly that night it still made her head spin. But also, it was nice to have a little crush, a little thing to get excited about. She hadn't felt this way about someone in a long time.

Their food arrived. Individual sized pot pies were set in front of them in beautiful ceramic pie plates with little leaves embellished on them. The smell was so delicious Adora practically started salivating. Yum. She definitely made the right decision copying Catra's order.

"This looks amazing as usual, Razz," Catra smiled appreciatively.

Adora nodded enthusiastically, "I wholeheartedly agree. I am so excited to dig in."

"Enjoy, dearies." Madame Razz smiled before walking away.

Adora immediately grabbed a fork and broke the crust. She had a fork full of pie almost to her mouth when Catra quickly intervened. Putting her hand on Adora's wrist, she said, "Stop! It's molten lava right now. You're going to burn yourself."

Adora paused, looking at Catra's hand on hers. Catra removed it quickly, as if it were hand that was molten lava, and put it on the table. Drumming her fingernails on the surface in an unconscious gesture. Adora looked down at the steaming forkful of food regretfully, putting it back down.

"Thank you for saving my…um…mouth." Adora could smack herself. Why did she have to be so damned awkward around her?

"Razz likes to serve the food right out of the oven without much warning. The first time I ate here, I scalded my tongue and the roof of my mouth pretty badly. Wanted to help you avoid that."

Adora smiled and nodded gratefully.

“I like the idea.” Catra said, thoughtful.

“What idea?”

“The calendar dummy,” Catra rolled her eyes playfully, “I don’t know how we’d sell enough to raise what we need but it’s worth a try. And if it works out, we could make it an annual fundraiser.”

“Oh, I love that!” Adora clapped her hands in excitement. Catra smiled at her. Adora smiled back. They looked at each other and for a moment it seemed like maybe there was a mutual connection. Like maybe the feelings Adora was experiencing weren’t one sided and there could be more between them than just a friendly lunch.

It was Catra who broke the stare, clearing her throat. “So now all we need is a photographer.”

“Um. Yes.”

Catra nodded, “I’m going to ask a friend of mine.” She paused and looked down at the pies, “I think they’re safe to eat it now.”

Adora smiled and immediately dove in. The taste was absolutely as wonderful as the smell. Somehow the mix of pretty basic ingredients mixed together to create the most amazing flavors.

With her mouth full, Adora gushed, “This pie is fantastic!”

Catra agreed, laughing. Probably laughing at both at her reaction to the pie and how quickly she was consuming it. She was only half done with hers while Adora was busy polishing off the pie in front of her.

“Hungry?” Catra asked, her mouth twitching.

Adora laughed, strangely not embarrassed. She was used to this reaction from people. Meals in foster care were not always

consistent. She learned to eat quickly to fill herself up, even if food wasn't scarce. "I've always had a tendency to eat quickly." She definitely didn't want to get into the why, "But now working at the firehouse, it's kind of par for the course to consume everything immediately in case we get an alarm."

"That makes sense. I hadn't considered that." Catra seemed thoughtful, "Why did you decide to become a fireman, or is it firewoman, I'm sorry, I don't actually know what to call you."

You can call me whatever you want Catra, is what she did not say.

"Firefighter works," Adora smiled, "Though there are not many women in this field, I think nationally it's only like four percent. In Bright Moon it's slightly higher at seven percent, but I'm still the first in my station." She hesitated; how much should she disclose? The 'why she decided to be a firefighter speech' typically took on three angles, the full painful truth, and the surface level truth and the generic 'to help people' truth. She didn't know how interested Catra was in the answer. This was just a polite question after all. Often the full painful truth made people feel sorry for her and she was a little tired of the victim narrative. At this point, only her close friends knew that version. She decided to give her the surface level truth.

"I've always wanted to become a firefighter. It's been a passion of mine since I was little. I used to play with firetrucks as a kid and visit the fire station on school trips and was totally enamored with the whole world of firefighting. But ultimately, I decided to pursue it because I had family who died in a housefire." Adora exhaled, for some reason that felt a little misleading. It wasn't. It was the truth, just not the whole truth. "The firefighters on the scene couldn't save everyone, but they saved one person and that left a real impact on me. Both because I wanted to help people prevent housefires but also because I wanted to be able to help people on one of the worst days of their lives."

Catra sat there and listed to her and seemed a little at a loss for how to respond. "Oh wow, Adora. That's an incredible story. I

have no doubt that you will help people.” Catra bit her lip and looked a little uncertain. Like she wanted to say something to her but was holding herself back. Whatever it was she wanted to say, she didn’t say, and instead took a sip of her iced tea.

“What?” Adora asked, curiosity piqued.

Catra took a breath, still hesitating. When she spoke, she spoke with hesitance. Gentle in a way that caught Adora off guard, especially coming from the person who had been snarky with her from almost their first meeting. “It seems like there is more to your story. Of course, I could be wrong, and obviously your story is yours to share however you want and definitely none of my business. It just seems like there is more then what you’re saying.” Catra looked her in the eyes, almost reading her thoughts. She softly added, “Am I right?”

Adora bit her lip and sighed. How did Catra manage to read her so well? They barely knew one another. And while there was clearly an attraction, they knew almost nothing about one another. Adora just learned Catra’s last name this week! But Catra’s very act of asking made Adora feel closer to her. Like the fact that she recognized there was more to know was somehow a hidden key to the walls that most people didn’t know Adora kept up. Her sunny disposition and general earnestness belied a person always struggling to fit in, always trying to make things good and easy, desperate for people to like her. Perpetually justifying her existence to the world. Something Dr. Mara, her therapist, quickly helped her identify as survivor's guilt.

“Yes. You’re right.” Adora looked at Catra and then looked down at her empty dish of pie. “It was my family’s home that caught fire. I was 12. Someone had left a candle lit in our living room and somehow the curtains caught fire and then I don’t know, poof, the whole house was engulfed quickly. We were all asleep when it happened. My parents died in their sleep from smoke inhalation. I always hope they died peacefully but I guess I’ll never know. They were found in their bed. I was in a different part of the house, and the smoke hadn’t reached me yet by the time the firefighters

broke through the house and saved me. A neighbor saw the flames and called the fire department. Our house didn't have any smoke alarms, or rather, I don't know if the smoke alarms had batteries. That part is fuzzy. I don't even really remember it all. Which is surreal. One moment I was falling asleep in my bed, my life normal, and the next I was in an ambulance on the way to the hospital. My entire world had changed in the course of a few hours. And if it weren't for the firefighters breaking into my bedroom, I wouldn't be here talking to you. I owe them my whole life. And that neighbor too."

She hadn't noticed that she started to tear up while telling this story. It had been a while since she shared so much of her past with someone. She felt vulnerable and yet very safe at the same time. Catra had been quietly listening to her and reached across the table to take her hands. Holding them as Adora cried softly. When she finished talking, she looked up and saw Catra looking at her empathetically. Her beautiful heterochromia eyes fixed on Adora with so much caring Adora almost started to cry again. Catra's hands in hers were moving gently, her thumb lightly grazing back and forth. The gesture was intimate. Knowing. Belying the relative newness of this relationship.

It was Catra who broke the silence. "Thank you for sharing that with me."

Adora gave her a water smile. "Thank you for asking." Adora tried to give a little laugh, her need to make things nice overtaking her need to allow this natural moment to unfold. "Well, this went in a direction I had not predicted. From sexy firefighters to me blubbering."

Catra sighed. Like she knew Adora was trying to make things 'easy'. She moved her hands back across the table to her half-eaten pie. Adora missed them almost immediately.

"So, maybe a topic change." Catra suggested kindly.

"That sounds good. I'll go." Adora smiled at her, grateful, wiping away the remainder of her tears. "Why were you so…what's the word? angry? when we first met?"

Catra smirked, "Oh that old chestnut. I was wondering if you'd ever ask me that." She scooped up the last bite of her pie, taking a moment to chew before responding. "Honestly, I have a love hate relationship with the BAWS volunteer program. We need volunteers, BAWS can't function without them, we simply don't have the budget to hire more full-time staff. But many of them let us down." Adora was thoughtful hearing this. Her mouth rounded to an 'oh.' She remembered the day she helped Catra and Scorpia with the new cats arriving when some of the volunteers failed to show. She hadn't realized this was a common issue. "They don't always come for their shifts, many times without notice, which means we can't depend on them. Often, they quit within weeks or months of starting. Probably as soon as they realize it's not always glamorous work. Like it's surprising that taking care of animals is more than just cuddling with them. Now, don't get me wrong, we have some amazing volunteers. Bow is a great example and Netossa practically runs BAWS! But they're not typical." Catra dragged a hand through her hair in frustration, "Especially in the cat area, we haven't had someone stay long enough to lead the orientations. So, I'm often the one doing them, and the whole thing frustrates me." She laughed, "Also, I'll be the first to admit that I'm not great at building trust with new people. Which is another story that I don't want to get into right now." She looked away for a moment and paused, finally returning to look at Adora. "I guess I don't have a good poker face about it."

At that Adora laughed, poker face? Not even close. "Yeah. Not so much." She'd love to know more about the trust issues Catra brought up. But it was clear Catra wasn't yet ready to discuss that. So, she let it go.

Catra grinned in response. She shrugged, "I can't help it. Diplomacy is not a strong suit of mine. Working in the world of non-profits can be tough. I love my work, and I truly love the

animals, but I'm not great at schmoozing, and I stopped getting invested in the volunteer program a few years ago."

"I get it; I can see how it would be hard to put on a happy face when your expectations are so low. I…um. I hope I don't let you down."

Catra looked at her then, very sincerely. "I don't think you will, Princess."

Adora blushed at that look. This felt like another transformational moment between them. On this non-date.

The moment was interrupted by Madame Razz, she had brought over a big slice of warm blueberry pie, with a scoop of vanilla ice cream and set it on the table with two forks. "You two look like you could use some dessert. Here is some delicious pie, dearies. On the house. I picked the berries myself!"

"Thank you Razz," Catra smiled.

"Yes, thank you! That's very sweet."

"It's nothing, dearies. Come back soon!" She cleared their empty pie plates and gave Adora a pat on the shoulders. Like she knew she needed a little extra support.

"This might be my favorite new restaurant." Adora said, practically salivating at the warm pie. She learned her lesson though; she should wait before digging in.

"I'm glad you like it. You should feel special, I don't let just anyone in on this secret spot."

Adora did feels special. She felt warm. She wasn't sure if Catra meant for that to sound flirtatious but that's what it felt like.

Catra continued, "Only friends know about Madame Razz."

Friends. That word flushed the warmness away. Leaving a tepid feeling in its wake. *Friends.* Is that all Catra wants them to be?

Chapter End Notes

One of the comments on the previous chapter asked what month Adora would be featured in on the calendar. I thought that was a delightful question so I created a poll. Please vote on my tumblr to let me know.

Notes: Recipe inspiration for the pie. How good does this look! I've been craving this pie every since. Madame Razz should sell these frozen and send them to me.

Catra in a henley makes me very happy. Here is a lovely example of what I was thinking.

Comments are my virtual Nutella :)

I am super beautiful

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Following their lunch, Adora didn't quite know what to do with herself. She felt antsy and thrown. Too much nervous energy. She decided to change into running shorts and tank top to go for a long run in a vain attempt to sort out her thoughts. Running typically helped her process, and if nothing else, it helped relax her mind. She knew she wanted more from Catra, wanted to invite her on an actual date, wanted to kiss her *outside* of a public bathroom, wanted to know how she took her coffee. But their lunch made things more confusing, not less. Catra had been sweet with her, kind, understanding. She showed a side to her personality that Adora had never seen before. If possible, that made Catra even more attractive, more interesting. Less of a novelty and more of a real person. But also, Catra didn't indicate an interest in pursuing more than a friendship. She used the word 'friends' to describe them.

Adora wasn't completely stupid. She realized that Catra must feel some attraction or she wouldn't have followed her into the bathroom that night, but her reaction afterwards and the way she treated her at BAWS, and lunch made things more fuzzy, greyer. Maybe she wanted sex, but not Adora herself. And normally that would work fine for her, but not this time.

Adora prided herself on being brave. She volunteered to run into burning buildings, it was in fact her job. She competed with others for the privilege, but somehow Catra made her cowardly. Like making a move might break her. For all her quirks, Adora had never been shy about pursuing people. She has been known to approach women in bars and invite them home with her. She has been mocked mercilessly by Glimmer for basically having sex on the dance floor with strangers when they'd all go out. But those flings had been easy, requiring no actual commitment or

attachment, and definitely no feelings. She hadn't had a real relationship before. No one she'd voluntarily call her girlfriend. She limited relationships to friendships. Only allowing herself to be vulnerable with those she loved and trusted, like Glimmer and Perfuma, and to some extent Mermista. Yet another reason she never pursued more than a friendship with that gorgeous woman. Sexual relationships were just that, sexual. It wasn't something she was consciously avoiding. She'd just been content with this arrangement for her life. And it didn't take too much effort for her to connect her abandonment issues with her disinterest in having a serious relationship. Her therapist would be proud.

Catra felt different. She didn't just want to fuck her and call it day. She wanted more. And that made her scared. She wanted to wake up next to her, watch her work, kiss away the worry lines. What was her favorite color? Why did she decide to work at BAWS? What did she do on a typical Sunday morning?

She ran aimlessly around the city for almost an hour, finally ending up at Bright Moon harbor, only a few short blocks from her apartment. She was sweaty and sticky from the afternoon heat, her moisture wicking clothing not down much to keep the cool. She decided to stop there, taking in the sight of the river. The water reflected the sun in a particularly beautiful way today. The light flickering over the waves was like peace personified. Magical. Looking at it calmed her. Her heart rate started to slow down after the brutal pace she'd set. The brisk harbor air felt good against the perspiration on her skin, making the tank top clinging to body a little less snug. She mindlessly started to stretch, grabbing her foot to work out her quadricep. The pain/pleasure of the stretch felt really good.

She had come to a decision. Her first priority would be the fundraiser. Deciphering her need for Catra would have to take a back seat to that. As much as she wanted Catra, and she very much did, she knew the animals had to come first. At least for now. Then maybe afterwards she could take a chance and pursue something more. It wasn't an ideal decision, but she felt it was the right one.

She continued stretching, dropping her heel along the edge of the sidewalk for a long calf stretch. She had her headphones in, half listening to her running list. Over the sound of 'Undrunk' by Fletcher, she thought maybe she heard someone calling her name. She squinted against the sun to look. In the distance, she saw Perfuma and Mermista on yoga mats waving frantically at her. She waved back. They gestured for her to come over.

Adora jogged over to them.

"Hey guys! Good to see you. What are you guys up to?"

"Adora, what a lovely surprise, come sit with us, we just completed our yoga routine." Perfuma said in welcome.

"Sure, I need to do stretching. I just finished a long run."

"Here gorgeous, take my mat," Mermista smiled, offering her the yoga mat she had rolled up next to her.

"Thanks M," Adora said. She made herself comfortable on Mermista's aquamarine yoga mat, moving the soles of her feet together for a seated butterfly stretch. Her strong thighs straining the materials of her shorts.

"It was good to see you out Monday, I almost never see you out anymore." Mermista continued, not trying to hide the fact that she was ogling her thighs, which were trying to escape the thin materials of the shorts she was wearing.

"So true, between the academy and now being a rookie, I almost never have the time, or I'm exhausted. It was nice to go out and see everyone. I had fun." Adora said with a quick smile that didn't quite reach her eyes. What she didn't add was that the night was the height of confusion for her that she was still reeling from.

"And your new *friend* seemed nice," Mermista said suggestively. Perfuma shot Mermista a look of warning, which she completely ignored.

“Um. Yeah. She’s nice.” Adora responded, a little confused by Mermista’s tone and Perfuma’s look.

“I don’t know if she liked *me* very much.” Mermista responded.

“Mermista…” Perfuma said in a scolding tone.

“What?” Mermista turned to Perfuma, “I just call it like I see it and Catra was not excited to meet me.”

“What do you mean?” Adora asked confused, “You two talked for less than one second. What are you talking about?”

“Uggg, come on Adora! Don’t be so obtuse. You’re cute and all, but like, sometimes you’re such a dumb blonde.” Adora rolled her eyes at that.

“Mermista please!” Perfuma said, her voice a little less nice than her usual dulcet tones, “We talked about this, this is none of your business.”

“Talked about what? I genuinely don’t understand.” Adora asked, her eyes moving between them in confusion, moving to a seated band stretch, crossing one leg over the other.

“Listen gorgeous, I think we both know that I am super beautiful. And…sometimes that can be intimidating to new people.”

“Intimidating…how?” Ignoring the comment of her being super beautiful. Obviously, she was but that was irrelevant.

“Uggg, Adora, could you be more obtuse?”

“Be nice, Mermista,” Perfuma says, putting her hand on Mermista’s arm in an effort to steer her.

“I’m going to need you to spell it out for me?” Adora responded, completely lost. She switches positions to get the stretch on the other side. But her eyes were glued to Perfuma and Mermista.

Perfuma finally took pity on her, and said very gently, "Mermista believes that Catra might have been jealous of her, like maybe she thought you and Mermista were an item."

Adora sat there thinking for a moment, unblinking, mouth a little parted, her eyes focusing on nothing. Starting to replay the conversation from the bar on Monday. Could Catra have been jealous of Mermista? It was possible for sure, but it would never have occurred to her. They had just come out of a pretty significant bathroom hook up. And the conversation at the bar with M was so brief. But she guessed they were doing their regular flirting bit, but it was so obviously a *bit* and nothing of substance. Unless maybe it wasn't obvious. Adore had her eyebrows knit together in consternation. Hmm. That could explain how odd Catra acted after they ordered their drinks. And if Catra was jealous does that mean she liked Adora? And by that token *didn't* like the idea of her being with someone else. Adora's mind was racing with too many what ifs. And this was still speculation on Mermista's part, it didn't actually mean anything…right?

"Earth to Adora," Mermista mocked loudly.

"What? Sorry, just processing. Obviously, she has nothing to be jealous of plus she and I are not together so…" she trails off, not sure how to finish that sentence.

"I mean…She's pretty hot, if you're not going there, you just let me know!" Mermista says suggestively.

"Mermista!" Perfuma and Adora exclaim in unison. Adora would never understand who or what Mermista was into, or what was up with her and Sea Hawk but sure as hell she would not be touching Catra. In fact, she would prefer she didn't even look at Catra. She could feel her neck get red at the potential of that happening.

"What! I'm only joking." Mermista, reading her thoughts, added with a wicked smile, "okay, like maybe 80% joking. In any case, wise up Adora! I'm glad I had a chance to talk to you about it. I had no idea you were so dense."

Adora sat there, moving through some mindless stretches and contemplated the idea of Mermista being right. She could feel the hope she had fostered inside of her building. She wasn't a fan of jealousy. Adora thought it was stupid when women she'd hook up with tried to make *her* jealous. Like jealousy was somehow a healthy emotion in a happy relationship. And Adora was never jealous of the random women she'd slept with. They could be with whomever they wanted! Though the thought of Mermista talking about Catra a minute ago clearly set her off. Hmm. So, if Catra thought she and Mermista were together, and was jealous, maybe it was a sign that there was a chance for them. She could feel the little flame of hope growing. It was something at least. Another part of her was laughing at herself and this whole situation. It felt very juvenile and was exactly the reason she avoided relationships.

Adora changed the subject, asking Perfuma about Scorpia. Instantly the mood shifted. Perfuma started to gush about how wonderful Scorpia was, how handsome she was and how easy it was to talk to her.

"Yes, it must have been really easy." Adora smiled, teasing, "When I talked to Glimmer Monday night, you hadn't come home yet."

Perfuma blushed. "Yes. Well. That."

Adora and Mermista laughed at her but with absolute kindness and love. Perfuma was such a sweet human being, seeing her happy was infectious.

A few hours later, as Adora was fixing her dinner, she got a ping on her phone. She picked it up thinking it was Glimmer seeking fashion advise for her dinner date with Bow and was surprised and happy to see Catra's name on the phone instead.

Catra:
hey Adora

Adora:
Hey!

Catra:
I've been thinking more about the fundraise and I really do like this idea. Thank you for coming up with it.

Adora couldn't help but get flustered at the tiny praise. Like somehow a thank you was the gateway drug to a relationship. She composed herself enough to try respond normally.

Adora:
Of course, I'm glad I can help. I am back at work Saturday and I'm going to spend some time tomorrow coming up with language for the captain's email so he can email it out.

Catra:
That sounds good. Also, my photographer lead panned out. An old friend of mine is going to help pro bono.

Adora:
Oh great. Maybe we can brainstorm some dates for the photo shoot so we can start to coordinate.

Catra:
That works. If you want me to take a look at your email draft, I'd be happy to.

Adora:
Yes! That would be very helpful. I'll email it to you tomorrow.

Catra*:*
okay

Adora wanted to keep talking but she had nothing of substance to say. She was even more off kilter following the conversation with Mermista and Perfuma. What she wanted to say was, would you go out with me? I wouldn't mind seeing you naked. What side of

the bed do you prefer? An old, and completely terrible, pick-up line came to mind. *Should I call or nudge you for breakfast?* She chuckled. She could just imagine Catra's reaction to that. Maybe a single raised eyebrow. It might be worth it just for that. No, just cool it Adora! Keep it focused on BAWS.

Adora:
I have to change my volunteer shift Tuesday. I work that day. Probably switch it to Wednesday. Hopefully by then, we'll get a few firefighter volunteers that we can review.

Catra:
sounds good, Adora.

Even via text, Catra saying her name was a turn on. This whole conversation was strangely a turn on. Adora knew that there was clearly something wrong with her. She returned to making dinner. Hoping it would distract her from her racing thoughts.

Chapter End Notes

Okay, I've officially caught up to my edited material. So I don't think I can publish twice weekly anymore. But you never know.

Adora's Random Running Mix. Random is right. Let me know if there are songs you particularly liked, or were new to you.

I'm still taking votes for what month Adora should be featured in on the calendar. Probably for a few more days. Don't forget to add a comment on why you chose that month. Vote here on my tumblr .

Mermista is a goddess.

Comments are my virtual Nutella :)

the Mermista-Adora show

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

After sending Catra the email draft, a switch turned on and Adora was able to communicate normally. Well, not entirely normally, she would still get flushed at a potential compliment or double entendre or just Catra saying her name. But between editing the email and talking about the calendar, she and Catra were able to actually text without Adora tripping all over herself. And now their conversations weren't just limited to the calendar, they talked about art and music, about Catra's cat, Melog, who Catra sent a picture of. Melog was a foster-fail dating back to the time Catra first started at BAWS. She took him in and then couldn't bring herself to give him back. The photo she sent was a selfie of Catra smiling into the camera with a sleepy Melog curled up in a sunny window. The smile Catra gave in the photo was so genuine and adorable, Adora couldn't help but grin in response. It was utterly adorable. She definitely saved the photo on her phone. They talked about Adora's time in the firefighter academy and how challenging it was but also fulfilling. Adora may have also sent Catra a photo of her taken by a fellow trainee. In the photo Adora was in uniform, but completely drenched from head to toe, sitting on top of the firetruck hood. The photo didn't show any skin, and you couldn't really make out the outline of her body because of the many layers she wore in her uniform, but it was still somehow sexy. She was laughing at the person behind the camera, her hand raised to try to stop the photographer from taking any more. Adora remembered that day very well, it was a highlight of a stressful training day. She and Lonnie, the only other female trainee, were setting up the fire hoses for an exercise and got into a massive water fight with the rest of the trainees. It was totally inappropriate, but so fun.

After she sent the picture, Catra responded simply with a "Wow." Adora blushed. Did that mean she liked it?

Adora told Catra how she met Glimmer and her whole crew of friends. Catra talked about her time as a vet tech at a vet clinic and how it made her pursue shelter work. Adora wanted to ask her how she took her coffee, something that for her felt strangely intimate but didn't quite get up the nerve to do it.

In between texting Catra, Adora got a call from Glimmer.

"Great news!" Glimmer practically yelled.

"What?"

"I got you a sponsor for the calendar! Senator Huntara's office is going to sponsor the printing! Now all the profits from sales will go directly to BAWS."

"That is incredible Glimmer! How did you swing that?"

"You know I have my ways. Blah blah blah, I explained how great it would look for our office to support the local animal shelter and, by proxy the first responders supporting the effort. Blah blah blah etc etc. You'll just have to give them a shoutout in the calendar. Which! Also, you'll need help with layout and design. And I'm not sure you're aware but my *boyfriend* is a graphic design artist."

"Boyfriend!!!?" Adora practically squealed. It had only been a week or two since they started seeing each other, but Glimmer moved on U-Haul schedule and it didn't surprise her *at all* that Bow did as well.

"Yup, he's making us dinner at his apartment. Bow, say hi," Glimmer put the phone on speaker.

"Hi, Adora!!!" Bow yelled from what sounded like across the room.

"Hi, Bow!" Adora yelled back. Glimmer took the phone off speaker and started speaking in a slightly more hushed voice.

"We made it official last night," she cleared her throat, "ahem. And this morning. And this afternoon. And we'll probably also make it

official *after dinner.*"

Adora laughed at the excess of information. "I get it, I get it. You've had sex. A lot. Some of us haven't had sex in a while so please don't rub it in."

"I bet you'd like someone to rub it in." Glimmer said, voice low and suggestive.

"Glimmer!!!!" Adora turned several shades redder.

"You know I'm only teasing. I'm still holding out hope for you and Catra."

"No comment. For now, I only have the bandwidth to obsess about two or three things at a time. So, work and the calendar are it. Catra is…Catra is something I'll have to pause on for now. Though I ran into Perfuma and Mermista yesterday and they shared an interesting theory with me." Adora told Glimmer the gist of the speculation.

"Wait, wait, wait, you did *not* tell me that Catra saw the Mermista-Adora show at the bar Monday."

"The what?"

"Oh please, Adora! You and Mermista have been eye fucking since you first met. I know it's moved in a more friendly direction, but Perfuma and I used to take bets on when you'd actually fuck after we first introduced you."

"What?! Really?" All of this was news to her. She knew they had a flirtation but did not realize how obvious it was to everyone else. And the fact people assumed they'd eventually have sex was a bit wild. "She's not even queer."

"Says who? You? Adora, you know I love you, but you have to get out of this heterosexist mindset about what relationships have to look like."

"Hetero…wait. I'm so confused. I mean, I know we're a little flirty, but Mermista has been on again off again with Sea Hawk since I've known her."

"Yeah? So? They're both queer and poly. I just can't with you. It's been years! Also, you know, Perfuma and Mermista dated for a hot second back in the day. Ex's turned best friends. Tale as old as time. How do you not know this?! For someone so smart you can really be so stupid." Glimmer let out an exasperated sign. "In any case, regardless of the fact that your flirting is now relatively innocent, it's also not *not* flirting. And if I were Catra, meeting Mermista for the first time, super sexy, drop dead gorgeous Mermista, and then observed the ridiculousness that is your dynamic, I sure as hell would assume you were fucking."

"Oh."

"Yes 'Oh'!"

Adora paused to think about it. If the roles were reversed and she saw Catra at the bar, flirting with a beautiful goddess like Mermista, she might also assume something was happening there. She guessed that might explain Catra's behavior that night. If seeing them flirt bugged her enough that she decided to go home early, maybe Catra was interested in more than just a hook up? Or she maybe she had been into her but just assumed she fucked around and decided she wasn't worth the effort. Or maybe all of this was nonsense and Catra was just Catra and didn't want to be at the bar anymore, nothing more. Adora felt like her brain might explode.

"Okay, I need to think on this a little more. In any case, you started to tell me about Bow volunteering to do graphic design."

Adora successfully got Glimmer to change topics. She had to force herself to listen because all she wanted to think about was Catra.

Hordak, true to his word, sent out her email to the other fire chiefs on her behalf. Adora was anxious to see the response. She hoped they would have at least twelve interested firefighters. And hopefully a few female firefighters. It would be awful after all this planning if no one expressed interest. Happily, this wasn't a problem. By Wednesday she had an amazingly decent showing of responses in her email. She had asked folks interested in participating to include a photo and pet preference. She was thrilled to see that there were at least four women who applied. Including Lonnie, her friend from the fire academy. She was excited to talk to Catra about the options. They agreed to meet after her volunteer shift. Adora was more than eager to see her again, it had been so long since they had lunch. Yet because they talked so much that week that she felt like no time has passed at the same time. Adora could barely contain her nervous excitement. The pups could feel it and gave her extra cuddles. The shift seemed to drag on because the universe knew she needed to see Catra again. Finally, it was time to clock out. Adora washed her hands, grabbed her bag, and tried not to run to Catra's office.

Catra was sitting at her desk but seemed to be daydreaming. Her eyes looking out the window and not on her computer. Adora gave herself a moment to just look at her. Catra was so beautiful. Her hair was up in a messy clip, a few tendrils falling down around her long neck. She was wearing a BAWS t-shirt, again a little too tight across the chest. Her tattoos accentuating her beautiful arms. Anyone would be so lucky to be with this woman. Adora signed; apparently a little too loud because Catra turned away from the window to look at her in the door frame.

"Hey Adora," she smiled.

"Hi," Adora managed, after clearing her throat, "you still free to meet?"

"Yes." Catra gestured for Adora to sit down at her little conference table in the room. She tried not to flinch when she felt Catra sitting near her. The table was small. Only two chairs, and their

proximity made it difficult for Adora to focus. What was this power Catra had over her?

"Um. So, we've had a great turn out of volunteers. I think we definitely have enough to choose from. And I spoke to the captain and he's comfortable with us using the fire station for the location shoot."

"Great and I have a few staff and volunteers who can help wrangle the animals the day of. Do you think next week is too soon to schedule?"

"No, I think that works. I think we can probably get it done in a day. I'm off Tuesday, Wednesday and Friday, and if those don't work, I could always ask to swap shifts with someone."

"Okay, let me text Double Trouble, they're the photographer friend I was telling you about, to see if they can do one of those days." Double Trouble responded quickly that Wednesday would work best.

"Perfect. I'll see if Glimmer can come help put everything together. Maybe Bow too since he'll be doing the layout." Adora shot a text to Glimmer to confirm.

"Okay, now lets take a look at these hotties." Adora chuckled nervously in response. For some reason she felt a little jealous that Catra wanted to look at *other* hot firefighters. Or really anyone, that was not her. She shook her head, trying to talk herself out of being ridiculous. This was the whole point. She wanted people to *want* to look at the firefighters and sell a shit ton of calendars. And Catra was free to find whoever she wanted attractive.

Reviewing the photographs, they quickly agreed to include all four women, leaving 8 spots for the rest of the crew.

"Rogelio works at my fire station, he's pretty cool, and I've seen that man out of uniform and I think our boy loving audience would like to see him." 7 spots left.

They spent the next hour or so reviewing candidates until they started to get to their final list with a few alternates.

It was now well past six pm and it seemed like most of the staff and volunteers had left, some stopping by to say goodnight to Catra.

Adora checked her phone and saw that Glimmer had responded, "Bow and Glimmer are taking the day off Wednesday to help! So, between them, you, the BAWS crew, Double Trouble, I think we'll be all set. And I'll obviously be there to help set up the trucks and do general stage management."

"Hold on princess, you're not going to be in the calendar?" Catra asked, surprise evident in her voice.

Adora tried not to blush at the nickname. "Um me?! Oh no, of course not. I'm sure I'd be more useful behind the camera. Plus, we have a good showing of women who applied, so we have a good gender balance already."

"Adora," Catra said, her tone chastising, "This was your idea, your calendar, you have to be in it!"

"I don't know, I don't think so, I honestly never really considered doing it. I thought of the idea to do a calendar, but it was Glimmer who thought up the whole "sexy firefighters with animals" idea, photoshopping a pic of me at the beach as an example."

"Photoshopped a pic? Beach? I'm going to need to see that."

"Um, it's kind of...um…a lot"

"Don't care. Let's see it, Princess."

Adora paused to consider, she knew she looked good in the photo, but it was so extra! Finally, she pulled out her phone and scrolled through her texts with Glimmer to find it. She wordlessly handed the phone to Catra. Catra didn't say anything, but her eyebrows went up, and Adora was positive Catra used her fingers to zoom

in the image. She cleared her throat and handed the phone back to Adora.

“Tell me again why you’ve decided not to be in this calendar?” she asked, one eyebrow up in challenge.

Adora blushed. Hard. But she mustered up her confidence to tease a little, “Why, do you like the picture?

“Adora…,” Catra said, reprimanding in her tone, almost with a warning.

“I think you liked it; gosh, that must be so embarrassing for you.”

Catra narrowed her eyes at Adora and bit her lip. Looking at her for just a touch too long; she looked like the teasing had set off a fuse. Her face shifted and it seemed like she came to sort of decision. Catra got up without a word and walked over to the door. Adora wrinkled her eyebrow in confusion. Where was she going? Was the teasing somehow too much? What’s going on? Catra closed the door and leaned on it for support momentarily, like she couldn’t stand on her own in that moment. Adora was relieved. So, if she wasn’t going to leave, what *was* she doing? After a few seconds, Catra locked the door and closed all the blinds, still facing away from her. Adora caught her breath. A flood of warmth filled her. Her heart began to race, and a rush went over her whole body. The air became electric as Adora looked at Catra from across the room. Adora was reeling from the rapid change of atmosphere.

They now had complete privacy.

Catra turned around and looked at her then, her face flushed. Without further hesitation she continued, “Adora…do I seem embarrassed?”

Chapter End Notes

um...soooo...smut? up the rating? keep the rating the same?

I'm just teasing, I've already written half of chapter 10 and I think it will require a rating shift. That okay with you?

I might need to add a chapter as well. Which means you still have time to vote on what month I should feature Adora in the calendar (if you want to participate). So far January is winning.

I'm going to try to keep to a weekly update now. More if I can find the time. Need something to read? Give my first fanfic a try, including the playlist.

Comments are my virtual Nutella :)

Do I seem embarrassed?

Chapter Notes

> This chapter is 99.8% smut. I'd say maybe the last paragraph is the only safe non smutty thing you can read. Rating officially updated.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora swallowed, hard, and shook her head no. No, she didn't seem embarrassed. She seemed focused; laser focused. On Adora. Not flinching when she looked at her, her intentions clear and purposeful.

Catra approached her, moving the chair with Adora in it so she was facing her. "How about now?" Catra straddled her, her hands on the sides of her face, stroking it with her thumbs. Adora swallowed almost audibly. Licking her lips in anticipation of what might come next. Catra looked her in the eye and for a moment seemed to second guess herself. "Is this okay?" she asked, a little uncertain. "Do you want to stop?"

The hesitation was almost sexier than anything else Catra had done so far. She wanted to make sure that Adora wanted this, that this was mutual. The little uncertainty was a little glimpse into Catra's vulnerability which Adora found utterly adorable.

Adora, feeling 100% more confident now, responded, her voice a little deeper, more needy. Her blue eyes turning darker, almost gray. "Yes, this is very very okay," further clarifying, she added, "I do not want you to stop. But thank you for asking." She smiled.

Catra smiled back, looking into her eyes with a little relief, her need very clear. She kissed her, mouth descending over hers. Soft and sweet. Slowly and deliberately touching their lips together as if for the first time. It started off as an 'I like you' kiss that slowly dissolved into a 'I need you' kiss. Getting deeper and more possessive. Catra nipped against her lips, daring her to open

them, which she very gladly obliged. They started to explore further, tasting each other. The sensation of it sent shivers down Adora's spine. The taste of her was everything she remembered and more. Small sighs escaping her without a filter. It was sensual, exploring, taunting, exciting. They kissed until they were forced to come up for air.

Adora pulled back to look at Catra's face. Her mouth was a little extra red, her cheeks flushed, her pupils dilated. This face she had stared at only hours before in secret voyeuristic pleasure from the doorway; now she could study it without hiding. She tentatively touched Catra's swollen lips with her fingertips, her cheeks, the nose peppered with the cutest little freckles in the world, the gorgeous heterochromatic eyes looking back at her with a small question. Almost a dare. Adora put her mouth on Catra's neck, licking her salty skin. Something she'd wanted to do as soon as she saw her at her desk earlier. She kissed along her neck, dragging her lips along the taunt skin, and sucking gently, trying not to leave a mark. She was an adult after all, she chuckled a little to herself. Catra started to breathe heavy, moaning softly, so very content at being kissed in a sensitive spot. Adora trailed light kisses up her neck to her mouth, closing over her lips again, exploring but with less caution. She could almost be content to stay like this forever, Catra pressing against her, their mouths needy and desperate and oh so warm. She dreamed about this. But reality was a thousand times better. And she wanted more.

Keeping her mouth firmly against Catra's lips, she moved a hand lower, trailing her fingers along the edge of Catra's shirt. She grazed fingertips underneath, touching her soft brown skin. She paused a little to give Catra a chance to pull back. Not feeling any hesitation, Adora moved her hand slowly up Catra's body. Her hand feeling the warm flesh underneath, it felt so good. Her hand finally landing on the curve of Catra's bra, moving her thumb to gently graze against the cotton material along her rib cage, the magnificent bend of her body. A shiver went down Catra's back and Adora felt the small goosebumps that appeared quickly afterwards.

“Please,” Catra whispered against her mouth. Adora smiled, loving more than anything hearing how much Catra wanted her. She’d waited for this moment, hoping, wishing, dreaming to have the chance to touch her again. She eagerly moved her thumb to Catra’s nipple, now hard against the fabric. Catra’s breath caught against her lips. Adora moved her fingers underneath the fabric to feel her hard nipples and let out a moan of her own; touching her was more thrilling. Adora paused to look up at Catra; her face flushed, and her eyes, closed for a moment, now blinking down at Adora with heat and a little challenge. Catra gave a little smirk, Adora couldn’t help but grin back. This girl was trouble. Catra moved her hands to the hem of her shirt and pulled it quickly over her head, tossing it to the floor without a moment of hesitation. Adora’s smile grew, looking at the peach cotton bralette in front of her, her hand under the cups. Catra looked down on her, taking her face between her hands again and kissing her deeply. She then slowly straightened, maintaining eye contact the whole time and took the bralette off, throwing it down in the graveyard of fabric on the floor.

Adora eagerly moved her mouth against her hard nipple, tongue lightly flicking at first before putting her whole mouth on it. Catra threw her head back with a whispered “yes,” wrapping a hand in Adora’s hair to encourage her, her fingers gently massaging her scalp. Adora could spend her whole night licking and tasting Catra’s nipples, the hard peaks puckered and hard against her tongue. She moved back and forth between her breasts, making sure to give them equal time and attention. Catra started moving against her, her hips starting to press with need. Adora knew she wanted more of Catra, wanted to feel more of her and clearly Catra felt the same. Her mouth still hot on Catra’s nipple, she moved one hand between them, her fingertips asking a question against the waistband of Catra’s jeans. Catra moaned acquiescence. Adora started to unbuckle the button of Catra’s pants, unzipping them to give her better access. She slipped a hand inside, over her underwear, already damp against her fingers. Catra moaned again.

Adora dragged her mouth off Catra's perfect breasts and hoarsely said, "I need you to stand up and take everything off."

Catra smiled down at her, "I didn't hear the magic word, Princess."

"Please, fucking please!"

Catra let out a raspy laugh. "It seems you want me, Princess. How embarrassing for you."

Adora smiled, a little rakish. "Do I seem embarrassed?" She responded, echoing Catra's words.

Catra laughed again, scooting off of her, catlike. She made a point of turning around, so her back was facing Adora, before hooking her thumbs in her jeans and pulling them straight down, her ass in the air taunting Adora, before stepping out of them. She was wearing matching boy short underwear. She turned around again, pulled them off quickly.

Catra stood up, hands on her hip and with a little scowl, said, "Now this is not fair."

What words did she just say out loud? It was truly impossible to process words when she stood naked in front of her. Adora dragged her eyes off the perfection that was Catra's body and looked at her in question and confusion.

Catra continued, "One of us is wearing too many layers."

Adora looked down and remembered that she was still completely dressed. She had not shed a single item of clothing. She grinned at the realization and quickly started unbuttoning her short-sleeved button down. Her fingers moving like lightening. All the while, very aware of Catra's eyes on her. She moved to her compression top next and threw that off, followed in short order by her sports bra. She looked up when she heard Catra's quick intake of breath. Catra had her eyes glued to Adora's body. She walked to her, pressing their bodies together. "You are beautiful,

Adora.” Adora blushed. The words, spoken by Catra, made her feel a little high from exhilaration.

“You’re beautiful,” she responded, kissing her again. Wrapping her arms around Catra’s more petite frame, their naked bodies warm against one another. Breasts pressed together. Catra started unbuckling Adora’s pants. Wordlessly pulling them down along with her underwear in one tug. Adora stepped out of them.

“Better?” she asked.

“Much.”

Catra lightly pushed Adora backwards towards a small couch against the wall. Adora felt the edge of the cushions on the back of her legs, forcing her to fall backwards onto the couch, Catra tumbling on top of her. They both started to laugh, tangled up together. Somehow this was easy, effortless. All of Adora’s doubt and confusion dissipated. This was simple and basic and yet at the same time, it also felt huge and meaningful. Adora effortlessly flipped Catra over so that she was now sitting in her lap, her breasts against Catra’s back.

“I see those muscles aren’t just for show,” Catra teased.

“Mhm,” Adora managed to respond, moving her mouth against Catra’s nape and back, kissing every inch of delicious skin. Discovering a new tattoo on her shoulder blade, she hadn’t seen yet, a beautiful abstract line tattoo of what appeared to be a scorpion, astrological sign perhaps? She made a note to ask about it later. She wrapped her arms around Catra, cupping her breasts and belly. Pulling her smaller frame close against her.

Catra groaned on top of her, “Please, Adora.”

Catra could ask for anything right now, just as long as she said her name first.

Adora mumbled against her neck, unwilling to stop kissing her nape, “Please what?”

“Please fuck me.”

Adora smiled against her shoulder, well since she asked so nicely, “How would you like me to fuck you, Catra?”

Catra took one of the strong hands holding her and moved them down, against her belly, over the curly hair between her legs, until they reached the warm slick part of her.

“Thank you for clarifying,” Adora laughed, gently starting to move her fingers in small circles, applying very little pressure. A whisper of contact. That was enough for Catra, she moaned, moving her hips against her hand, making Adora’s breath catch at the contact against her. Adora continued slowly, keeping her rhythm at pace with Catra’s hips. Catra moved her hips faster, grinding against her, Adora’s fingers sped up to keep pace.

Catra’s breath started to catch, her movements more frantic. Adora moved her fingers lower, until they were almost inside her, pausing again to gauge consent. Catra, reached down and helped guide Adora’s fingers inside, first one, then two. “Adora, yes, please.” She moaned her name, riding her fingers, moving her own fingers over clit to help build on the pressure. Fucking Catra was electric, it consumed her whole body. Having her say her name was somehow the most beautiful and hottest thing she’d ever experienced. Her sounds, the whimpers, the moans, the shivers were all consuming. Catra started to convulse, contracting her muscles, and releasing with one high pitched moan, “Adora, fuck!” she groaned, her body collapsing backwards onto her, panting heavily. Her body slick with sweat.

Adora slowly removed her fingers, turning Catra so she could cradle her into her arms, holding her close until her body stopped shuddering. She pressed her face into her neck, gently kissing her there.

Catra finally started to stir in her arms. “Catra?” she asked, a little uncertain, not sure what she was asking.

“Hey Adora,” Catra responded, turning to look at her, smiling. “That was fucking amazing.”

Adora grinned. Proud of herself. “You were fucking amazing,” she responded, she moved her fingers into her mouth, licking them. “And you taste good too.” Catra looked almost shocked watching her.

“Um, you did not just do that!”

“Do what?”

“You know what, Princess! Bold”

“I’m bold? Miss, ‘I’m going to pull down the blinds and straddle you’.”

Catra laughed sheepishly, “Well you bring it out in me.”

“Thank you?” Adora laughed, a little self-effacing.

“Don’t thank me yet, Princess. Give me a minute and then I hope you’ll be very thankful.”

Adora blushed, almost shy, “This isn’t transactional, I’m not expecting remittance.”

Catra moved her hands to Adora’s face. As she studied Adora’s expression, her features softened. She suddenly looked very sincere. “Adora,” she started, her thumbs grazing over her face, “I’m sure you’ve noticed, I’m not…I’m not great with people. I have great friends, people who I trust and love, people who I chose to spend time with, but more often than not, I prefer the company of animals…and maybe toddlers.” She gave a little chuckle at that joke, “They are honest, they have no guile, they are who they are with no hesitation or agendas and that makes me feel comfortable. Maybe it was the way I grew up, maybe it’s just who I am, but it’s hard for me to be open with someone new.” She bit her lip, hesitating for the moment before continuing, “Adora, you…there is something about you that I’m very drawn to.

I’m comfortable in my own skin around you. That’s not something I can typically say about someone. And just now, you made me feel so very very good, and if I can make you feel even a quarter as good as you made me feel then I’d be sincerely grateful.”

Listening to Catra, Adora’s whole body grew warm. It made her happy to hear that she made Catra feel so comfortable. This was what she wanted. She hoped to have something real with her, something more than just a hook up. But at the same time, a part of her started to panic. Here was someone she could see herself falling for opening up in a way that she never allowed herself to do ever before. Holding Catra, both physically, and now emotionally, felt like responsibility she’d never invited with anyone. She thought she wanted it, and she was pretty confident she did, yet somehow it felt so new and raw and scary. It felt like a lot of responsibility and it made her both excited and terrified.

Catra must have sensed her spiraling because all of a sudden, she started to plant little kisses on her face. Featherlight touches to her cheeks, her eyelids, her forehead, her mouth. Somehow knowing the way to bring some calm back to her pounding heart. “Adora,” she whispered quietly, “Nothing needs to be decided right this moment. I just want to make you feel good. Would you let me make you feel good?”

Adora looked back at this beautiful naked woman in her lap and nodded quietly. Catra smiled at her and started kissing her more deeply, pulling her hair out of its high ponytail so it fell around her shoulders. Groaning in delight, “I’ve wanted to do that since I first saw you,” Catra whispered against her lips, wrapping her hands in the blond tresses. They stayed locked together for several minutes, Catra kissing her, their tongues dancing together, resending currents of desire down her body. Catra pulled back and gave her one more little peck before moving off the couch and crouching in front of her. Adora swallowed seeing her on the ground looking up at her.

Catra crooked a finger at her; Adora leaned forward in complete compliance. Catra kissed her again and then whispered in her ear.

“Scoot forward, Princess and open your legs for me. With your permission, I’d really like to fuck you.” Adora could only nod mutely in response.

Catra wasted no time. Massaging and kissing her thighs and her belly, getting closer and closer to her very obvious desire but not close enough. She was making her squirm and curse, until finally Adora could not wait any longer, and begged Catra to fuck her like she’d promised. Catra smiled against her belly but didn’t make her wait any more, moving her lips to her clit. Starting to gently lap around it, drawing more moans and curses from her.

“Please, Catra, I need…I need more,” she pleaded between gasps. Catra mouth between her legs moved faster, using her lips, her tongue, even her teeth to lick and suck and tug at her. Adora grabbed at Catra’s hair, tangling her fingers in the wild tresses for support and also encouragement. Without removing her mouth, Catra moved a finger inside her, crooking the finger the same way she did a few minutes ago but this time hitting her inside in exactly the right spot. Adora responded by moving her hips underneath Catra. Moving in rhythm with Catra’s every thrust, getting the full heady sensation while whispering encouragement and praise. Catra used her free hand to grab her ass to help keep them in time together. It didn’t take very long for Adora to reach a peak, both thanks to Catra’s talented fingers and mouth, but also fucking Catra earlier was more than enough to get her close. Catra sensing her orgasm, put another finger inside her to add more pressure and closed her lips over her clit to suck gently. That was all she needed. Adora came strong but silent, like a broken tea kettle, her hips off the couch for her final tension and glorious release until she collapsed, spent and exhausted. Her whole body tingling. Catra gave quick kisses on Adora’s inner thighs and belly, kissing up her body until she was back in her lap, holding her close.

Adora felt like she could pass out very easily on this remarkably comfortable couch if given half a chance to. But reality made that impossible. They really needed to fuck in a bed next time. Adora only had so much energy right now. She used all of it to open her

eyes and look at Catra, planting a little kiss against her lips. “Thank you.”

Catra smiled at her, almost timidly, “You’re very welcome, Princess.”

They sat together on the couch, naked and cuddling for a long time. Both catching their breath, kissing occasionally, and just enjoying being in each other’s arms. Catra pulled a blanket over them and Adora allowed herself to hope for the future. Could this be her normal? Could she allow herself to get used to this glorious woman cuddling in her lap? Could she trust someone with her heart for the first time. Before tonight she would have said she wanted to at least try, that Catra was 100% worth risking her heart. But this night of passion and emotion, with Catra opening up more then she ever has before makes her uncertain. And a little scared. What if she wasn’t capable of loving someone the way they need to be loved? What if Catra began to trust and Adora broke her heart?

Chapter End Notes

Bralette inspiration.

Tattoo inspiration.

real talk. This chapter completely threw off my story line. So I have to do some direction change. I didn't think anyone would mind though. :)

Feel free to message me or follow me on tumblr. Or tell me who I should be following. It's all new to me. I'm a very late adopter.

Comments are my virtual Nutella :) But especially for this chapter. Smut is not my specialty.

I’ve always had a thing for people in uniform

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Okay, so I’ll coordinate with Double Trouble over the set up and props and anything else we might need day of, and you can help me procure it from the station,” Glimmer said thoughtfully, pen at the corner of her mouth before taking some notes.

Adora was so relieved Glimmer agreed to produce the photo shoot. She had no idea how much work went into prepping for this type of affair. In her mind, the photographer takes a picture, and the models smile. She hadn’t considered what the models would wear or if the animals would match them, or if props were needed, call times, the weather. Apparently, even the ‘light’ was important. She was completely clueless. But if they were going to sell as many calendars as was needed; they’d have to look really professional.

“I looked at DT’s portfolio online and they’re really good. I’m super impressed. I think I’ll be able to send out call times to the models, both human and otherwise in a day or two. We have access to the firetruck, right? And hoses? And water?”

“Check, check and check. I’m still kind of shocked how cool the chief is being. His girlfriend Entrapta said she’d come day off to help with ‘tech.’ I’m not quite sure what that means, but I figure the more hands the better.”

“That’s great actually, sometimes shoots can get very technical. She’d probably be helpful to Bow too in post-production.”

Adora nodded as if she understood, but honestly, she had no clue what Glimmer was talking about. She understood the words individually but strung together in a sentence she was utterly lost. Her mind wondered to last night. She wondered if now would be a good time to tell her what happened. Memories of Catra’s hands,

her body, her mouth, her noises have been invading her senses since she got home very late last night. She still felt like her skin was on fire. She hadn't showered, unwilling to wash the smell of Catra off quite yet. She was surprised Glimmer hadn't immediately noticed how flushed she was. She tried not to read into the fact that they haven't talked since last night. For some reason Adora thought she'd text this morning, but then maybe Catra thought the same thing. Fucking she understood, fucking was easy. No one needed to text. Next morning check ins were never needed, in fact they were discouraged. Dating was different, relationships were emotionally driven. And she was pretty sure she wanted one of those with Catra. But at the same time, she didn't know if she was built for something like that. Dr. Mara was back in her brain, asking the questions. 'Do you not want a relationship or is a relationship something you think you can't or shouldn't have.' She really needed to schedule a tune up with her therapist. It had been a month and clearly, she had a few things she needed to flush out.

"Where did you go?" Glimmer bopped her pen on Adora's nose.

Adora blinked in response, refocusing on their conversation. "Oops, sorry, what did you just say?"

"I was just talking about animal pairings. Did you and Catra finish picking out models last night?"

At that question, Adora's whole face turned beet red. Her eyes wondering to the side in a terrible attempt to hide.

"Uh-oh. What happened"

Adora bit her lip and if possible, turned redder.

Glimmer's eyebrows shot up, "Noooooooo," she screeched. Was she so obvious with everyone or is Glimmer just really good at reading her?

"You didn't? Oh my god, you did! Tell me everything. Who made the first move? What happened? Was it good? Aaaaah, this is so

exciting!" Glimmer was practically buzzing in front of her.

"Okay, okay. Calm down. To answer your question, yes, we picked models. I'll send you their info…and um…and to answer your other question, yes, we um, hooked up…and it was…very good. I mean *very, very* good." She exhaled at that, "Glimmer, I thought I'd had great sex before, but I was wrong. Somehow for being our first time, it felt like we really knew how to make each other feel good. I've never experienced anything like it and…" she started to falter. A frown creasing her brow, "…I don't know how to handle it. I'm so overwhelmed all of a sudden. I thought I wanted this, but after having it, I feel so anxious. Like I'm going to fuck it up and that maybe I shouldn't do this. I don't want to hurt her. You've known me for years; you know I've never done a relationship before."

Glimmer, to her credit, went from titillated to concerned and supportive very quickly. She reached over and took Adora's hands. "Look, Adora. I can see you're anxious, but just cause you haven't done this before, doesn't mean you can't do this or that it won't go well. Also, sometimes people do get hurt in relationships, that is a potential outcome. But, we both know you'd never intentionally hurt her, so trust that at least. You like her right?" Adora nodded quickly, she sure as hell did, "Okay, then that's a building block. And frankly, your insane chemistry is another building block. And you don't need to know anything else right now. You don't need to solve all the other problems in your head. Just one step at a time. Think short term. Maybe you ask her out on a date? Maybe you buy her a coffee? Maybe you ask to meet her pussy?" Adora laughed at that, her creased forehead relaxing for a moment, "Sorry, I couldn't help myself." Glimmer grinner, "You told me she had a cat, right?"

"Right."

"Okay then." Glimmer paused, her sneaky smile returning… "Sooo, who initiated?"

Adora laughed again, sex was definitely a popular topic of Glimmer's, so she wasn't surprised she wanted all the details. "A lady never tells," She responded demurely, smirking.

"You're no fun!"

Later that night, Adora broke down and texted her.

Adora:
Hi

Catra:
Hey, Adora

How was it possible that a short text with her name could make her blush? But it absolutely did. Adora sat on her couch, her heartrate already elevated at five little letters.

Adora:
How are you?

Catra:
I'm very good. A little tired today. Someone wore me out yesterday.

Adora:
Oh is that right? I'm so sorry

Catra:
Oh I bet you are princess.

Adora smiled. Maybe this wasn't as awkward as she imagined it would be.

Adora:
Nah, you're right. I'm not in the least bit sorry. In fact, I wouldn't be sorry if it happened again.

Catra:
Oh is that right?

Adora:
Mhm

Catra:
Hmm…I could entertain that possibility.

This Adora could do. Flirting wasn't as emotionally taxing. It came easy to her. And flirting with Catra…that she could do all day.

Adora:
Anything I can do to make you fully consider it?

Text bubbles appeared and disappeared as Catra started, stopped, and started typing again.

Catra:
What are you wearing…?

Adora looked down at her basketball shorts and tank top, not feeling particularly sexy.

Adora:
Not much

Catra:
Want to come over?

Fuck fuck fuck. Yes. Yes, she 100% did want to come over, but she had to be at work at 6am tomorrow, which meant she had to be up at 430, 5am at the latest. She looked up at her clock. It was 9 now. Already a little past her bedtime. Fuck. She didn't want Catra to think she wasn't interested but she also knew there was

no way she'd be able to drag her ass out of bed after a sleepover. Not that Catra asked her to stay over…was she asking that? Crap. She was starting to spiral. What happened to the easy flirting? She shook her head at her ridiculous overreaction and forced herself to respond.

Adora:
I really REALLY do. But I have work tomorrow and I have to get up super early…raincheck? Please?

Catra:
Sure princess.

Okay, that wasn't so hard. Why did she have to react so strongly? Catra's an adult, she understands demanding jobs. If the situation were reversed, she wouldn't have been mad at all. Disappointed sure, but not mad. She should really set up that Dr. Mara appointment soon. This new development was clearly a trigger for her. A fantastic, delightful, albeit scary as shit, trigger. But still a trigger. Adora licked her lips and tried to shift the conversation back.

Adora:
May I ask what you're wearing?

Catra:
That's my line.

Adora:
And it's a good one. Just trying to help myself out since I don't get to see you tonight.

Catra:
Hmm. I'll consider that…for a trade?

Adora:
Trade? what are your terms?

Catra:
I'll tell you what I'm wearing if you send me that beach pic from yesterday.

Adora laughed out loud. Ha! She wished she could tell Glimmer about this. She would just die knowing that she was right about the photo being a thirst trap. She quickly scrolled through her phone and sent the pic over.

Adora:
…Well

Catra:
Got it.

Sorry to disappoint Princess. I'm in my pjs. Nothing special.

Adora:
We can work with that …

Catra:
Is that right?

Adora:
Mhm. I assume you're texting with one hand…doesn't that mean the other one is free?

Catra:
…Adora

Adora:
Yes?

Catra:
Are you asking me to do what I think you're asking me to do?

Adora:
Maybe…do you want to maybe call me instead?

No response for a minute. Her heart started to race. Finally she looked down in her hand where she felt her phone buzzing. She smiled. I guess they were doing this.

The rest of the week flew buy in a flurry of planning and phone calls and discussions. Everything was on track for the photo shoot. Glimmer and DT planned out every detail, directing Adora, Catra and the rest of the team to prep with props and animals and other assorted details. She and Catra texted and called frequently, but Adora never took her up on the raincheck and Catra never asked again. Something was holding her back and she had a feeling that Catra was starting to sense it and pull back in response. Adora was so afraid of intentionally sabotaging the relationship that she was starting to accidently sabotage their relationship. It was like a self-fulfilling prophecy. It was now Tuesday, the day before the shoot, Adora arrived for her volunteer shift a little early so she could check in with Catra and Scorpia. She walked by Catra's office, she could see the light on through the blinds, but the door was closed, and the curtains drawn. Heat rushed to her face as she remembered the last time she had been in Catra's office with the blinds closed. She considered knocking but thought better of it. Catra almost always had her door open, so maybe she was busy. Adora walked away a little disappointed but also, if she was honest, a little relieved. She didn't know how to act around Catra in person now. Do they kiss hello? Do they act like nothing happened? What were the rules!?

She found Scorpia instead; at least with her, she was guaranteed not to have any awkwardness.

"Adora! I am so excited for tomorrow. And I can tell the animals we've chosen are too! This is going to be so much fun!" Scorpia squeaked. "Did Perfuma tell you that she got the co-op to agree to cater? She's bringing all kinds of treats tomorrow!"

Adora smiled. Her friends were awesome! "That's great, Scorpia! I didn't know we were getting catering!"

"Oh yes, Perfuma has it all planned out, she's even bringing food and treats for the animals. She really is the most amazing person, Adora. I'm so lucky, I can't believe she, uh…" Scorpia started to blush, not sure how to finish that sentence.

"It seems like you're both kind of lucky to have found each other." Adora finished for her. "How is it going it going between the two of you?"

"Oh wow. So, so good," Scorpia eyes were lit up in excitement at the mere opportunity to discuss Perfuma. "I don't have a lot to compare it to, I haven't really dated that much. But this feels so easy and right. She's so kind and generous and beautiful. I mean, you know her, so I don't really have to tell you but, but wow, she…have you ever met someone, and the connection is almost instant and that relationship just kind of takes on a life of its own? Like you know she'd be your lady friend?" Scorpia was gushing, and then looked to her for an actual answer.

Lady friend? That was probably the cutest thing she'd ever heard. Of course Scorpia would call her that! Adora paused to consider how to respond. The connection with Catra felt pretty instant to her, even though initially the chemistry presented itself as angry contempt. She smirked thinking back to their first meeting and that disastrous orientation! She wondered if Catra talked to Scorpia about her. Scorpia wasn't making any hints to that effect. So then maybe it wasn't her place to discuss it yet since their situation was still quite undefined and getting more tenuous by the day. She decided to give a moderated response. "Um…I. To be honest, I haven't had any…lady friends…but yeah. I hope one day to be that fortunate."

"Oh you definitely will! You're so great, Adora! Even if I didn't know you myself, Perfuma always has the nicest things to say about you."

Adora blushed at that. It made her feel good for the rest of her shift. And she was very relieved that Shadow, the crazy cat who attacked her, was no longer there. She wondered vaguely where

she went, hopefully she left to become a mouser like Catra mentioned. She should ask her. Her shift went by quickly. She thought more about what Scorpia said about her 'lady friend.' She found that she really liked thinking that Catra could be hers. She felt strangely possessive of her in that thought. And warm. The more she thought of calling Catra hers, the happier she got. Why had she been panicking? She had the opportunity to be with a beautiful, intelligent, sharp, witty, fucking sexy human being. She would be so lucky to date her.

She got more and more excited to find Catra at the end of her shift.

But she when finished up, the door to Catra's office was still closed, but this time the light was off. She was gone.

The next morning, Adora arrived bright and early to her station. She wanted to be there to meet everyone else to make sure set up went well. She commandeered a fire engine and was driving it out back when folks started to arrive. She jumped off the rig to greet them.

"Hello darling, you must be Adora." Adora assumed this was DT based on the giant bag of camera equipment they were carrying.

"Hi! Yes, thank you so much for doing this."

"You're very welcome, darling. Anything for our dear kitten, and her kittens." DT laughed at their own joke. Adora assumed they meant Catra and momentarily panicked at the very familiar way they were addressing her. She shook her head to focus. Today was about the photoshoot.

"Anything I can do to help get us started? I was just about to go grab some fold out tables and chairs for all the props and food etcetera."

"Ooh, will you be lifting things? Can I watch, darling? I've always had a thing for people in uniform." Adora paused. She wasn't wearing her uniform. Just some shorts and her compression shirt. Wait, were they hitting on her? Before she could even think to respond, she heard Catra's voice.

"DT," she said reproachfully, walking up, "We discussed not sexually harassing people you've just met."

DT laughed and gave Adora a wink before walking away, "Whatever you say, Kitten."

"Hi Adora," Catra said neutrally. Adora smiled hello, trying to read her expression. Catra wasn't exactly scowling, but she wasn't smiling either. Her face was flat, casual, like they were mere acquaintances. She tried to shift their conversation.

"I missed you at BAWS yesterday. I was hoping to see you during my shift."

"Oh yeah? We must have just missed each other." Her response was neutral again, not bad, but definitely not familiar. A little cold. Adora could feel a little ripple of dread move up her body. What happened?

Adora swallowed, "Catra, are you…is everything okay?"

"Yup, why wouldn't it be? Need some help with the table and chairs?

"Ah. Sure."

As they set up the table and chairs, the rest of the crew arrived to help for the day. Perfuma laid out the food, Scorpia drove in the air-conditioned van with the animals, Bow and Glimmer were conferring with DT on lighting and set up, Entrapta and Captain Hordak came by to see what was needed. In a funny turn of events, it turned out Entrapta knew Scorpia and Catra from college and was excited to stay and assist. She wrangled a few

staff to help her bring some ladders from the station to get better angles.

Finally the first model arrived, and the photoshoot started. Adora ran around helping grab gear from the station for DT and Glimmer, Catra hung back with Scorpia, helping to make sure the animals had what they needed. Aside from their quick interaction that morning, Catra didn't say anything to her again. Every time Adora approached her, she seemed occupied and uninterested in talking. It was like their time in her office hadn't happened. Like their chats and texts hadn't happened. Adora swallowed her anxiety and focused on the photoshoot. Maybe she could convince Catra to talk during their break.

"Want to come sit and have a bite with me?" Adora asked as they broke for lunch, gesturing to a little area behind the station that provided some nice shade and privacy.

Catra paused to consider the question and nodded. They grabbed a few tasty looking sandwiches and drinks from the food table that Perfuma just refreshed.

Adora waited till they were settled in against the wall of the station before really looking at Catra.

"Um, so about last week." Adora started to stay.

"It's fine." Catra interrupted.

"What's fine?" Adora asked, confused.

"We're fine, Adora. We don't need to talk about it."

"But I want to talk about it…about us."

Catra gave a little chuckle, though the laughter didn't quite meet her eyes. "Us? Adora, like I said, it's fine, I get it. I get what that was. We don't need to make a big deal out of it and we don't need to discuss it." Again with that word, 'fine.' Certainly, whatever was happening didn't feel fine to her.

“What do you mean, you get it? What do you think it was?”

“Do you really need me to say it?”

Adora paused, her brow wrinkling, “I guess I do.”

Catra exhaled a little, frustrated by this conversation. “It was a hook up. A really great hook up.” She smiled humorlessly, looking at her sandwich and not at her, “but just a hook up. And…it won’t be happening again.”

Adora struggled to process what she was saying. It hadn’t felt like any hook up she’d experienced; but Catra was saying that that’s what she thought it was. Or was she saying that’s what she wanted it to be. And what about the phone call the next day? Was that part of the hook up? That’s not what Adora wanted. At all. And clearly she had done a really bad job making that clear. She hoped it wasn’t too late to try.

“Catra,” she started to say, licking her lips and looking directly at her so she wouldn’t be misunderstood. “I had hoped that it…that we could…try for more. I really like you.”

“Adora, you don’t have to say that. I get it. I’m a big girl. You don’t do relationships. I should have picked up on the signs.”

“Signs? What do you mean? I know…I know, I’m not great at this. I’m sorry. And I’m sorry if I wasn’t clear on what I wanted before. It’s something I’m working on. But I’m telling you the truth.”

Catra looked unconvinced and vaguely annoyed, but before she could respond, they put looked up when they heard a shrill voice yell, “Adora!”

Glimmer jogged up to her looking panicked. “Adora!” She practically yelled again, “We are fucked.”

“Okay, calm down, what’s going on? What happened?”

“One of the models just texted me; he was called way to a fire. He’s not coming! And he was supposed to be Mr. January.”

“Crap,” Adora responded, understanding the urgency now. “Do we have a backup?”

Glimmer bit her lip, looking guilty. “No. It’s all my fault, I had confirmed everyone again yesterday and didn’t bother with the back ups because everyone seemed so committed to today. I’m so sorry. I didn’t account for fire emergencies.”

“It’s not your fault Glim, it just happened. Maybe we can call one of the back ups now, maybe move up the rest of the shoot while we wait?”

“We can’t do that, you know how you firefighters are, you’re very scheduled. It’s not like I can make the rest of the models come early.”

“Shoot, no. You’re right. Let me think.”

Catra huffed in exasperation next to them, “Adora, don’t be an idiot. We have a backup option right here.”

Glimmer looked over at Catra, in her panic, she had barely registered she was sitting next to Adora. Her eyes brightened in excitement as her brain clicked into understanding. Adora, meanwhile, stood there in confusion until finally the realization of what Catra was saying finally dawned on here.

“No, you don’t mean…you don’t mean me? I’m not a model!”

Glimmer laughed, “Adora, Catra’s right, don’t be an idiot. None of these firefighters are models. They’re volunteers. And you can be too. And we all know you have some delicious looking abs that you can show off.”

“Glimmer!” Adora screeched, turning red and doing everything in her power not to look at Catra.

“Whatever friend, you know I’m right. Now get your butt into the station and don’t come back until you’re wearing your uniform. Though don’t bother with the top…”

Adora looked between the two of them, Glimmer looked giddy and excited, Catra’s face turned neutral again. She didn’t seem concerned that they had been interrupted and they wouldn’t have a chance to finish their conversation for a little while. She really wanted to stay and talk, but clearly that was no longer appropriate. She finally let out a relenting sign. She guessed she was going to be a model.

Chapter End Notes

Oof. These two. Throwing my arms up in the air!

I might need to increase my chapter count again. I didn't think you'd mind but wanted to give you a warning.

Also I saw this fantastic Catradora art on Instagram. It has absolutely nothing to do with my story but made me very happy and excited. I guess the universe agrees we need more Adora in a firefighter uniform. If I had even an ounce of artistic talent I'd love to draw the Adora January spread. If one of you has any any interest in doing that, send me a message on tumblr and we can collaborate.

Feel free to message me or follow me on tumblr. Or tell me who I should be following. It's all still new to me.

Comments are my virtual Nutella :)

Do you want me to apply the oil?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora paused at her bunk, thumbing through the spare clothes she kept in her cubby. She shook her head a little grimly. It was one thing to pose at the beach with some friends, it was a hell of a lot different to pose for a calendar that would be consumed by (hopefully) hundreds of people. And being *January* meant that she would be the very first person they saw. Her mouth pulled in a straight line. She knew Glimmer, there was no way she was joking about showing off her abs. She needed to suck it up. This was *her* idea. Everyone was here because of something she started, to help the animals. She knew she had to suck it up and pick out a sports bra. She looked through the few she kept at work and settled on a simple black one that provided good support for her size C breasts but didn't completely compress them. Glimmer would be pleased.

She changed into that quickly and threw her blue crewneck Bright Moon Fire Department t-shirt over it. She put on a pair of tight but breathable shorts underneath. She typically wore those under her uniform pants so as not to overheat. Meandering over to where the crew kept their turn out uniforms, she stepped into her heavy boots, already inside her turnout pants, pulled them up and shrugged on her suspenders. She grabbed her jacket from the hook, buttoned it up, and slung her helmet over her shoulders. It was surreal to be putting on thirty pounds of turnout gear so casually; without rushing to an emergency or to a training exercise. She caught a glimpse of herself in a mirror; she looked strong, like a warrior, unstoppable, ready to tackle this photoshoot. She took a deep breath to calm her nerves, following it up with a few finger guns for good measure. She grinned. She's got this…maybe.

Walking back outside was surreal. Her friends had rarely ever seen her in full turnout gear; and the few times they did, it was definitely only in pictures. Certainly Catra had never had. Everyone stopped what they were doing for a moment. She tried to project confidence as all eyes turned to her. Catra, currently crouching next to a very cute ginger Pitbull mix, looked like she was having trouble swallowing. Adora made eye contact with her. Yes, she wanted her to find her sexy and yes, she wanted Catra to want her as much as she wanted Catra. But she also tried to telegraph warmth and affection in her gaze. I like you, her eyes screamed. Please don't give up on me. Catra looked away to pet the ginger pit. Adora desperately attempted to hide her disappointment.

"Oh my god! Adora!" Glimmer's voice brought her back to reality, "Damn girl, I'm going to insist you wear that next time we go all go out."

Adora blushed and tried not to squirm under the scrutiny of so many eyes on her.

"Ah, where do you want me?" she asked Glimmer and DT, trying to keep her voice neutral.

"Okay, darling, the theme for this month is 'New Years Eve'. Think cone hats, and horns, and mistletoe, maybe some streamers and confetti. We'll have you and the pup wear a few different accessories, maybe kiss under the mistletoe. You'll start with your full gear on and then I'd like a few without the jacket and then with just your sports bra. Work for you?" DT barely waited for her to nod before he turned to Scorpia and Catra, "Is Shuri ready?"

"Oh boy, is she ever!" Scorpia announced, excited to get in on the fun.

Adora looked over at the cute pup Catra had been holding; her co-star Shuri was currently wagging her tail and sticking out her tongue. It seems Scorpia was right, she was very ready to get in front of the camera. She smiled, what an adorable dog! And she

was the absolute perfect size! Scorpia handed Shuri's leash to Adora and gave her a little bag of treats so Adora could get Shuri's undivided attention.

Adora crouched down and let Shuri sniff her fingers to familiarize herself with her scent. It didn't take long for the pup to headbutt her giant ginger face into her hand, seeking love and snuggles. Adora was very happy to oblige, scratching behind her ear and giving her lots of kisses. She could hear Glimmer and Bow laughing behind her as she told Shuri how sweet and wonderful she was and how thrilled she was to spend time with her. "You're going to be adopted so fast, sweet girl. No one will be able to resist your beautiful face." Shuri looked at her with such love and trust that Adora almost melted. She resisted the urge to give her the full bag of treats, rationing only 2 for this first meeting.

"Okay Adora, let's have you guys walk over to the rig." Glimmer said, bringing over a few props. Putting a shiny silver cone head on Shuri and a matching one on her.

"I like how you crouched before, do that again and look at Shuri for a few shots and then look at the camera." DT started directing her in different poses and positions, with Glimmer running in and out of the shot with different props for them to try on and Bow trying to get Shuri's attention so she could face the camera. Some with her helmet on, some without. At one point, Entrapta climbed a ladder and dumped a bunch of confetti on them both.

Glimmer asked Adora to shed her jacket. Underneath was her sexy, but still conservative, Bright Moon Firefighter t-shirt with suspenders. They had Entrapta climb the rig so she could dangle the mistletoe above them. Adora patted her chest to get Shuri to jump on her and lick her face underneath it. Without even seeing the picture, she knew it would be absolutely adorable. Who could resist a sweet dog like this!

And then came the moment of truth. Glimmer asked her to shed the t-shirt but to keep the suspenders on. "Adora, do you want me

to apply the oil or do you want to do it yourself?" She asked her innocently, but with a playful twinkle in her eye.

"Oil?!" Adora looked horrified. What did she mean oil?

DT jumped in to explain with a bored tone, as if they were simply giving directions to a lost motorist, "You know, for your abs, darling, it really helps them stand out on camera." At this point, Glimmer wasn't even trying to hide her amusement, holding a little bottle of baby oil in her hand. Adora's eyes flickered to Catra. To her delight, she was looking back, her mouth slightly open in bemusement over the whole situation; though she quickly realized she had been caught looking and looked down at Shuri instead.

Okay, if she had to do this, then maybe she would make this a little more fun. Maybe make it really hard for Catra to dismiss her. She handed Shuri's leash to Bow, and started to slowly shed the suspenders, looking at Catra the whole time. Willing her to make eye contact. When she finally did a moment later, Adora slipped the suspenders off her shoulders, grabbed the hem of her t-shirt and slowly pulled it over her head, tossing it in the grass. It wasn't lost on her that Catra had done something similar a week ago in her office. Licking her dry lips, she slipped the suspenders back on over her black sports bra. She caught the bottle of oil that Glimmer tossed her, and then, as if she were in some stupid hair commercial, squeezed out some oil, letting the liquid drop half a foot into her other hand. Tossing the bottle back, she painstakingly and methodically applied the oil to her abs. Glimmer walked over to hand her a towel and whispered in her ear, "Please save some of that Catra eye-fucking energy for the camera."

Adora let out a short laugh, cleaned her hands and tossed the towel on the grass next to her t-shirt. When she looked back at Catra, she had stopped looking but she could almost feel her heartbeat racing from across the yard. Adora wished she could close the distance and whisk Catra away, bridal style, to a more private place. Apologize for fucking this whole thing up and then *really* make it up her. But with a dozen people's eyes on her, and even a few animals, she knew that was not an option.

The rest of her photoshoot went by quickly. Adora had fun in front of the camera, letting Shuri lick her face and jump all over her. They even tried a few shots of Shuri wearing her helmet. Her head was big enough that it stayed on relatively well. Adora grabbed the towel to clean off her oily abs and threw her shirt back on. When she looked over at Catra, she was pointedly *not* looking at her anymore. But the act of not looking felt very intentional and also somehow intimate. Adora slipped away to change out of uniform and came back just in time to see Mr. February posing with a happy looking bearded dragon in a red bow tie (for valentines' day perhaps?). Captain Hordak and Entrapta were giddily watching from the sidelines, taking pictures with their personal phones. Watching them made her smile, it was their Emily that helped make this whole photoshoot possible after all. Her eyes moved back to Catra. Catra must have just been looking at her because her eyes darted away, not wanting to be caught.

The rest of the day went by without incident. All models arrived promptly; the animals behaved beautifully. And when Shuri came back from her walk with Bow and saw Adora, she came bounding at her at full speed, toppling Adora over with her enthusiasm. "Hi, sweet girl! Did you miss me?" After that, Adora refused to give Shuri back to Scorpia. Insisting on spending the rest of the shoot with her. The day was almost over when Bow walked over to give Shuri some snuggles.

"Adora, I think you're falling in love." Adora looked up at Bow in a panic and quickly glanced at Catra, who was starting to load up the van with the animals. What? No? Wait? Maybe…back to Bow. How did he…? Bow looked back at her in confusion when then it finally dawned on her that he was talking about the beautiful pit-pull mix in her arms that she hadn't been able to give back. She exhaled a little under her breath.

"Yes! But can you blame me? She's so lovable and clever. And her coat is so soft! I can't stop petting her. How have you been able to get away with not adopting dogs volunteering for so long!"

Bow laughed, “Adora! You clearly don’t know me well. I have two newly adopted dogs at home, and my dads’ adopted three, and I even got half my siblings to adopt!” He chuckled and added conspiratorially in a whisper, “And, I’m pretty close to getting Glimmer and Perfuma to adopt one. I think by the end of the year, all of your friends will probably be taking home a pet!”

Adora pouted dramatically, “But I can’t adopt her, Bow; even if I could convince my landlord to let me have a pet, I have an insane schedule. I’m away 2 or 3 full days a week. It’s kind of impossible.”

“That’s tough, Adora.” Bow said sympathetically, giving Shuri some head scratches.

Entrapta, appearing out of nowhere, interjected, “So you would adopt this canine if you were able to have her with you during your work shifts?” She paused, “Oh, were you two having a private conversation? Sorry, I guess I should be going.” She started to walk away.

“No wait, stop. You’re welcome to stay, Entrapta. It wasn’t that private a conversation. Yes, I would definitely want to adopt her if I could bring her to work.”

“You should ask Hordak to let you train her as a fire station mascot. While less common place today than a century ago, during horse-drawn fire engine times, it’s not unusual for fire stations to adopt strays or donated dogs and train them to search for live victims trapped or buried in rubble. It would be a fascinating experiment to see if this canine could adapt to this type of work. From what I’ve read about pit pulls, they are very receptive to training, highly obedient, can pull heavy weights and highly intelligent. And their sense of smell is forty times stronger than that of a normal human; they can even categorize different scents around them. It would be interesting to run genetic diagnostic tests on this canine to uncover the rest of their breeding origin to identify her other natural capabilities.”

Bow and Adora blinked at Entrapta in complete awe and shock. Then they looked at each other and smiled. Adora was definitely going to try to adopt this dog.

"Thank you, Entrapta! That's a wonderful idea. I'll talk to Captain Hordak as soon as possible."

As everyone was cleaning up, Adora tried once again to approach Catra to talk. It was difficult to get privacy with so many people milling around, but she knew she had to try.

"Catra? Can I have a moment?"

Catra looked around to see if anyone was in earshot. When she realized they were alone, she turned back to her and said, "Adora, look," she exhaled in tempered frustration, "I don't need to talk. We don't have anything to say to each other. I'm grateful this shoot went well, I'm grateful that you thought to do this, but other than the calendar and BAWS, we don't have anything we need to discuss."

"Catra please…" Adora started to say, but Catra was already walking away, signaling to Scorpia across the lawn that she was coming over to help with the last few animals that needed to get loaded.

Fuck. This just got a lot more complicated. But Adora knew that that Catra was worth the effort. That she did in fact want her, wanted a relationship with her. And she knew that despite what she just said to her, Catra wanted that too. She just hoped that it wasn't too late to change her mind.

That night, and for the next week, Adora started campaign 'woo back Catra.' She sent her texts and emails. Some were serious, asking her for another chance to explain herself. Promising her that she was not interested in just a hook up. Explaining how she hoped to make things right again. Other texts were goofy. A lot of pics and videos of 'a day in life of Adora,' including pics of her at

work, clips of her video chatting with Shuri and Netossa at BAWS, gifs of her being silly during a workout. No longer closeted about her feelings, she recruited their friends to assist. She gave wrote silly love notes and poems and gave them to Bow and Scorpia so they can pass them to Catra at work. She ordered a chicken pot pie from Razz's restaurant and had it delivered to her for lunch. She asked Glimmer to help her photoshop the picture of her and Melog in the sunny window with word bubble over his mouth asking her to give Adora another chance. The day of her volunteer shift, she sussed out her favorite drink and left it at her closed office door (an extra hot cortado, whatever that meant).

At first it was cute and funny, but as the week dragged on Adora started to feel like maybe she was wrong. That this was no longer appropriate. Maybe Catra didn't actually want a relationship with her, and this was turning into harassment and not a good-natured effort to 'woo' her. What if this was not about hurt feelings and miscommunication? Maybe Catra simply didn't want anything to do with her. A full week passed since the photo shoot with no response from Catra. While it was painful, Adora understood her overtures were clearly unwelcome and she should stop.

Bow and Entrapta had been working hard on putting the calendar together and it was almost ready for final touches and printing. It looked genuinely amazing. Everyone efforts truly paid off. The animals featured were absolutely adorable, it would be impossible not to fall in love with them. The human models looked phenomenal. DT truly made them look both tasteful and sexy at the same time. Adora blushed looking at herself. Twice! Bow had made her both the cover model and Ms. January. On the cover, she was in her helmet, sports bra and suspenders, abs glistening (thanks Glimmer!) with Shuri licking her under the mistletoe while she laughed good naturedly. For January, she and Shuri were excitedly looking up, their silver cone hats on, enjoying the confetti raining down on them. The calendar was perfect as far as Adora was concerned, but they needed to have Catra proof it before giving final approval.

She decided it was time to give her a call. Something she hadn't done yet this week.

Catra picked up after a few very long rings.

"Hello," she answered formally.

"Hey, Catra," Adora said, her voice a little lower than normal, "thanks for picking up." No response on the other line, she exhaled and continued, "Listen, I know you don't want to talk to me right now. And…um. I guess, I'm starting to accept that. This call isn't about us. I just forwarded you the calendar file from Bow. We need you to proof it before it goes to print. Take a look and if you think it looks good just reply to the email. You…uh. You don't have to talk to me anymore. I promise to stop bothering you." Still no response from Catra, but the line wasn't dead, so she had to still be listening. Resigned she said, "Look, I'm at work, so I won't take up more of your time. But I just wanted to say, Catra, I'm sorry. For everything." Her voice caught; she could feel the full emotion of that statement flood over her. Her acceptance that Catra didn't want to try again making her genuinely sad. The lump in her throat hard to swallow. She would not cry on the phone. But before she could say anything else, the alarm went off at her station, with a voice over the intercom announcing a four-alarm fire. She swallowed the lump quickly and spit out, "Fuck Catra, I have to go," and hung up the phone.

Chapter End Notes

> I had so much fun writing this chapter. I hope you enjoy reading it as much as I enjoyed writing it. I'm basically done with the next (and final chapter) too, so hopefully I don't have to make you wait a full week before posting.
>
> Please check out my post on tumblr to learn who Shuri is. She was based on a real dog from my life. The friend in the photo doesn't actually sport a mustache in real life, but I found the emoji hilarious. In case you are curious, I did name her Shuri after the character in Black Panther.

Feel free to message me or follow me on tumblr.

Comments are my virtual Nutella :)

You like me?

Chapter Notes

> "It's hard keeping your heart open. It makes you vulnerable. But it doesn't make you weak, and I have to believe it's worth it." ~Perfuma

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The next few hours were both the longest and shortest ones of Adora's life. Her station and a few others arrived at the scene of a massive blaze in a six-story apartment building looking dangerously close to spreading to the apartment buildings next door. Before long there were firefighters everywhere, with command staff, ambulances and news vans beginning to arrive. Adora was chosen to be part of one of the crews sent up to look for any potential victims. They quickly climbed the stairs to the top. When they got to the sixth floor, smoke was everywhere, it was impossible to see more than a foot in front of them. Adora was never so grateful than now for the thermal camera mask her department recently purchased for each team member. The lightweight, wireless mask allowed them to both see in the dark but also gauge thermal heat levels to identify unconscious or disoriented victims. She remembered Captain Hordak sharing that Entrapta had been part of the development team for the product. That woman had a tray of tiny cookies coming her way! The team systematically knocked down door after door, checking for any signs of life. It was in the last apartment that Adora spotted a small thermal reading under a bed. She scooted down to see if she could identify it and found a little girl, maybe 10 or 12, clutching a kitten. Adora breathed a sign of relief to see that the little girl was still breathing and radioed down to her command team that she had found a victim and was making her way down.

Adora wasn't thinking, she acted purely on impulse and training. She held the little girl close against her chest, throwing a damp towel over her face to help prevent any more smoke inhalation.

She quickly made her way down the stairs, barely remembering how she got outside, working completely on autopilot until after she had deposited the little girl into a waiting ambulance. Only then did she fully absorb what was in front of her. She realized the little girl was still clutching her kitten, mewing almost silently in her arms. Adora vaguely wondered if she'd met this kitten at BAWS before but shook her head at the errant though. It was irrelevant! She became aware of people yelling and screaming behind her. "Hope," she heard over and over again. Two crying parents descended upon the little girl. Through tears, they said they hadn't been able to find her before they escaped the apartment, and when they didn't see her outside with the huddled group of neighbors, they were terror stricken.

"You saved her, you saved our little girl," Adora accepted their grateful hugs. But it took all her remaining strength to stay upright during this interaction. The reality of the rescue hitting her like a punch in the gut. Memories started to grab hold of her, and she could almost physically remember what it was like to be carried out of her home all those years ago by the firefighters saving her life. She knew she needed to do some breathing exercises to avoid a full-blown panic attack and made her way over to the command area to take her helmet off and drink some water, the urge to throw up almost overtaking her. She was relieved to hear the all-clear over the radio for the 4th and 5th floor as the crews methodically checked each residence for victims. She slid down the rig she was leaning against to try to regulate her breathing, using Dr. Mara's techniques of breathing in for a count of four, holding for a second, and then breathing out for a count of four.

After a few minutes she could feel herself returning back to semi-normal, enough that she could finally take stock of her surroundings. She finished another bottle of water and then went over to the command team to ask if she was needed, Captain Hordak told her she was relieved for now. She nodded and walked away for some fresh air. She squinted and, in the distance, she saw, rather than heard, someone waiving and calling her name

from the crowd of onlookers. She slowly approached, her vision a little fuzzy from the smoke and recent panic attack until she finally heard and saw who was yelling. Catra.

“Adora!” Catra was shouting her name and moving her arms frantically to get her attention.

“Hey,” she said, her throat dry, despite the two bottles of water she had just consumed, “what are you doing here? Are you okay?”

“Me?! Am I okay?” Catra looked panicked and incredulous at the question, “Yes, I’m okay. When I heard the alarm at your station and saw news of the fire on tv, I got really worried. I honestly don’t even remember driving over here, but I must have gotten in the car and steered it here.” Catra bit her lip and tussled her hair, an unconscious gesture of concern. “I…I got so scared that you might get hurt and I needed to see for myself that you were safe. I…I know I have been so stubborn and a little stupid; I wouldn’t, couldn’t allow myself to forgive you because…well because I like you so damned much and that’s very scary. And you made it really hard and…I didn’t want to risk getting hurt again…but when…” Her face blanched, almost white, “but when...when I thought I might actually lose you I…” Catra stopped rambling when she saw how big Adora’s smile was. Her eyebrows furrowed in response, “What?”

“You like me?” Adora teased, grinning, trying not to look smug.

“You’re such an idiot,” Catra responded, but her face looked utterly sweet and very, very vulnerable.

“I like you too,” Adora jumped in, still smiling. The fire, the panic, the anxiety starting to melt away.

Catra shook her head at her with smile, looking like she was debating how to respond. She raised a hand to Adora’s face, thumbing her cheek. Adora leaned into the touch, turning her face to kiss Catra’s palm gently and looked back at her with hope and

with all the feeling she'd been trying to keep under wraps. Catra responded by gently pushing their faces closer, brushing their lips together. Adora signed and deepened the kiss, locking them in a sweet and tender embrace. She vaguely heard the crowd around them clap and hoot in support. Who doesn't love a reunion kiss?

One year later

"Babe, do you know which box has the cereal?" Adora yelled behind her, the razer blade poised in her hand.

"Mmm, probably the one marked kitchen pantry," Catra yelled back from their bedroom, teasing. "But don't bother, I ordered take out, it should be here in 20." Adora smiled gratefully, her girlfriend knew her so well. It had been relatively easy move, first loading boxes from Adora's studio into the moving van, then boxes from Catra's apartment and then unloading them all here, in *their* apartment. However, since Adora stubbornly refused to hire movers, she was both tired and very, very hungry.

Adora made her way to the bedroom, sneaking up behind Catra and wrapped her arms around her waist. She pulled her tight against her chest and kissed her neck. "Twenty minutes, hmm…I can think of something we can do pass that time."

Catra laughed her signature little husky chortle, which never failed to make Adora melt, turning around in her arms. "Oh yeah…and what would that be?"

Adora grinned and swept Catra up into her arms and then quickly deposited them both on the mattress laying on the floor, the bedframe still in several pieces against the wall. Both of them laughing. Adora crawled up Catra, using one arm to pin her arms over her head, and the other to cup her face and pull her in for a deep kiss. Catra groaned her approval, meeting her mouth and moving her legs to wrap around Adora's waist, bringing their

bodies that much closer together. Adora smiled and moved to the sensitive area under Catra's ear, mouth open to nip and lick along the length of her beautiful neck.

"This is an excellent way to spend twenty minutes." Catra groaned her approval.

Adora continued to kiss her neck but moved to pull up the Bright Moon Fire department sweatshirt Catra stole from her, bunching it up around her chin. She let go of her arms, using both hands to start kneading the magnificent breasts underneath. She felt, rather than saw, how hard her nipples were at the contact. She smiled realizing this, moving her mouth to them, her hand flipping up the thin fabric so she could tweak at one and mouthe at the other. Catra arched her back in approval, moving her chest that much closer towards Adora's lips.

"Mmm, yes please," she whispered. Catra moved one hand to tug at Adora's thick hair, trapped in the rigid ponytail, encouraging her wet mouth on her body, and moved the other hand to her grab at her perfect, tight glutes that she'd seen her girlfriend work through many diligent squats, pushing their hips together. The friction created making her moan softly.

Suddenly, without warning, her whole body froze.

"What? What happened?" Adora asked, her face popping up in confusion.

Catra chuckled, "Um, it seems we have company."

Adora followed her gaze and realized that Shuri decided to follow them into the bedroom and had just made herself very comfortable on the mattress. She lay on her back with her paws up in the air, tongue panting to the side, obviously looking for some affection of her own. Her goofy pit smile making it impossible to be mad at her. Her feline sibling, Melog, not far behind her, sat in the windowsill and looked at them all with much disapproval. Adora burst out laughing.

“Rude! You guys are such wet blankets!” Adora wagged her finger at them both as if they understood. Shuri had the wherewithal to look a little guilty, Melog however, looked superior and haughty without an ounce of remorse. Almost like he was judging them for their ridiculous human behavior.

“Listen kids, we have to establish some ground rules now that we’re all living under one roof.” Catra said, in a mock serious tone.

Adora laughed above her, reaching down and grabbing Catra’s face to give her a quick peck before sitting up on her knees.

“She doesn’t mean it guys; we love you and we know you just want a little attention.” Shuri barked once in agreement.

Catra shook her head. “Oh, I see how it’s going to be, the three of you taking sides against me? Hmm…Maybe I should rethink this whole moving in together nonsense.”

Adora had the wherewithal to look a little hurt, pretending to feel shocked by Catra’s statement. “Oh, no you don’t.” Adora laid back down, on top of her, pinning Catra’s entire body to the mattress. “You’re not going anywhere!”

“Oh yeah? What are you going to do about it?” Catra teased, “Squish me to death?”

Adora paused to consider, then started grinning. “Not quite.” And then reached down and started to tickle Catra’s sides, knowing that was her most sensitive spot.

Catra collapsed in laughter and giggles. Melog looked concerned from the windowsill, about to pounce on the bed to save his human. Shuri looked confused, almost like she thought she should join in somehow.

“Okay, okay, I give up. I’ll stay.”

“Promise?”

“I promise,” Catra sealed it with a kiss.

They were all interrupted by Catra’s phone vibrating in her pocket.

“Food’s here!”

“I’ll get it babe”

Adora ran out to grab the food and when she returned, she saw that Catra was busy unpacking a box of decorations, taking out two framed calendar prints and leaning them against the wall. She was smiling. It was last year’s BAWS calendar. She had two framed photos made of the cover and of the month of January. She also pulled out the secret calendar she asked Bow to make for her last year, the one featuring Adora and Shuri every single month.

Adora looked at the frames and beamed. The little idea of hers had been an incredible success. They had met and exceeded their $10K goal last year, with request for the calendar going global. It seemed Glimmer wasn’t the only one who thought sexy firefighters and shelter animals go well together. A few weeks ago, they shot next year’s calendar, and she suspected the calendar would be an annual fundraising tradition moving forward. Adora was grateful, both because it brought Shuri into their lives and helped bring her and Catra together, but also because it spurred on a new initiative for the fire house to adopt and train shelter dogs to help with fire emergencies. A trend that was slowly making its way to other fire houses at Bright Moon. It gave more shelter dogs loving homes and assisted fire departments to save more people. It was a win, win.

She wrapped her arms around Catra again, tucking her chin in the crook of Catra’s neck, and looked fondly at the frames. Catra softly squeezed the arms draped on her belly and looked up at Adora behind her. “I love you,” she said, her tone and face open and sincere, full of feeling and trust.

Adora smiled, her eyes brimming from the enormity of feeling she had for this amazing woman and the little unit they'd created together.

"I love you too."

Chapter End Notes

(For those of you joining this story late, I truly enjoy the kudos and comments, I read and respond to them all! I really appreciate them!)

This was bittersweet friends. I loved writing this fic. I'm sad to finish it but I'm also excited for these two crazy kids to have their happy ending.

Adora was based on this beautiful firefighter from Arizona. I mean wow. Definitely worth checking out the whole calendar or just google female firefighter calendar.

Also, I read this great cnn article about lightweight wireless masks and immediately thought of Entrapta.

Would love to attempt a one shot after this. If you have ideas, please comment or message me on tumblr. I have some chapter fic ideas as well; I might post those on tumblr as well.

I also created a dedicated twitter account. @enigm17a.

For those of you who've been reading from when chapter 1 was first posted, thank you for sticking it out! I know it's hard to commit to a new fic and relatively new author. Everyone else, thanks for reading, posting kudos and writing comments. I am very appreciative.

As always, comments are my virtual Nutella.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!